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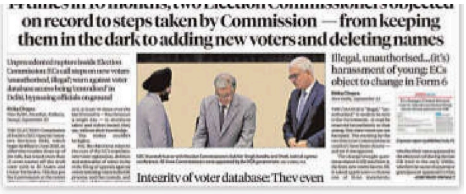
POLITY · PG 2–4 | GOVERNANCE · PG 5–6 | INTERNATIONAL · PG 7–9 | ECONOMY · PG 10–12 | ENVIRONMENT · PG 13–15 | SCIENCE & IDEAS · PG 16–20 | SOCIETY · PG 21–23 | PRELIMS POINTERS · PG 24–25

Front Page

LEAD · GS II POLITY & CONSTITUTIONAL BODIES

EC papers over objections within, presents united front in SC affidavit

Poll panel says the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls is legal and its process justified; says no change in Form 6; observations and questions by Election Commissioners are not decisions of the Commission


on record to steps taken by Commission — from keeping them in the dark to adding new voters and deleting names

Illegal, unauthorised...(it's) harassment of young; ECs object to change in Form 6

Integrity of voter database: They even

The Indian Express report published on September 23

Ananthakrishnan G by a unanimous decision of the

THE EXPRESS INVESTIGATION — The affidavit came in the wake of a September 23 report that 14 Election Commissioners' notes objected on record to steps taken by the Commission. THE INDIAN EXPRESS

In an affidavit filed before the Supreme Court, the Election Commission of India sought to clarify that observations, suggestions and questions by individual Commissioners were just that, and not the ECI's decisions. It said the Special Intensive Revision of the electoral rolls is legal, its process justified, and that the petitioners' allegations relating to changes in voter registration procedures and decision-making process are misconceived.

The ECI's affidavit, filed in response to a petition by social activist Rakesh Kumar Singh, said it "has been approved for filing… by a unanimous decision of the three members of the Election Commission, i.e., the two Election Commissioners and the Chief Election Commissioner".

'Unanimous' — and silent on who was told. The affidavit is, in one sense, a defence of unanimity. Approved for filing by a unanimous decision of all three members, it insists that the Commission's major decisions on the SIR were taken collectively. Notes recording suggestions, observations or queries by individual Commissioners, it argues, do not themselves constitute decisions of the Commission and are part of the consultative process.

EC PAPERS OVER OBJECTIONS WITHIN, PRESENTS UNITED FRONT IN SC AFFIDAVIT · CONTINUED

That distinction would answer an objection raised before a decision. Most of the 14 notes recorded over 10 months by Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, objecting to decisions taken in the Commission's name without their knowledge, were written *after the fact* — about decisions already taken, systems already built, orders already issued and cases already filed.

The issue the investigation raised was not whether the Commission eventually approved the decisions. It was whether two of its members were being consulted and informed about actions carried out in the Commission's name.

On Form 6 and ERONET. On restricted access to the IT system where electoral rolls rest for the statutorily backed Electoral Registration Officers, the affidavit said "ECINet is the tool through which those authorities act and no entry is added or deleted or modified except by the order of the ERO". It said the ECINet team remains obligated to ensure that EROs are able to perform all their statutory functions, including exercise of discretion, smoothly and without any hitch on the portal, as per law.

The ECI also termed as "misleading" the contention that Form 6 was amended, and said that only the Additional Declaration annexed to Form 6 was amended to introduce the concept of "mapping" — to connect the details of the applicant with the earlier SIR of 2002/2003 data, by requesting the applicant to provide the details of the electoral roll entry of the earlier electoral roll of self, parents or grandparents.

WHY IT MATTERS — Appointment, tenure and functioning of the ECI as a multi-member body; the rule of majority under the 2023 Act; judicial review of a constitutional body's internal process; Forms 6, 7 and 8 and the ERONET/ECINet architecture. The highest-probability GS II mains theme this cycle — read alongside the Hindu's account of the same affidavit.

GS II · JUDICIARY & DIGITAL RIGHTS

Censorship, gag on investigations: Publishers move SC against privacy law

Digital News Publishers Association, which includes several major outlets, says the DPDP Act lacks a journalism exemption

A group of 21 news publishers has challenged India's privacy law in court, arguing it would trample investigative work and let New Delhi identify journalists' sources, documents show.

The government last year announced implementation of a privacy law to protect digital personal data of users, raising compliance requirements for platforms like Meta and Google. The publishers have said that since media outlets were not exempt, the law was an invasion of press freedom.

Media companies received assurances in an August meeting with the government that the law would protect press freedom, but not having a written carve-out for journalists like those in the European Union, Singapore and Britain was alarming. India's Digital News Publishers Association said in a confidential filing at the Supreme Court.

CENSORSHIP, GAG ON INVESTIGATIONS: PUBLISHERS MOVE SC AGAINST PRIVACY LAW · CONTINUED

Fear of sources at risk. News publishers are concerned that a federal authority created under the law can impose fines for non-compliance, and grant powers to New Delhi to block access to any information in the "interests of the general public", which would curtail press freedom, DNPA said.

In an August letter to the government attached to the lawsuit, the group said India "has chosen to grant broad exemptions to the state, while failing to extend any corresponding protection to the press". No response was cited.

It can also deter whistle-blowers from sharing information on corruption, corporate wrongdoing or electoral malpractice with reporters, the DNPA argued. The "nakedly unguided" provision must be quashed, the DNPA said, adding that the power "can extend to privileged communication in possession of a reporter or the informant".

WHY IT MATTERS — DPDP Act, 2023 and the absence of a journalism exemption; Article 19(1)(a) and the *Puttaswamy* proportionality test; comparative carve-outs in the EU, Singapore and Britain; chilling effects on sources and whistle-blowers.

GS II · ELECTORAL ADMINISTRATION

Judges of Bengal tribunals ask EC to fix portal, drop Aadhaar authentication

For uploading orders on SIR appeals

Judges of Tribunals appointed by the orders of the Supreme Court to decide appeals of those affected by the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls in West Bengal have flagged at least twice in the last four weeks that the Election Commission requirement for **Aadhaar authentication** in its portal is holding them back from issuing final orders.

Official records show that the judges had taken exception to the introduction of the Aadhaar authentication required for them to issue orders on the appeals in September, and again less than two weeks ago. Just three days after the Aadhaar-authentication screen was introduced on September 21, the judges sought its removal, in writing, on September 24.

JUDGES OF BENGAL TRIBUNALS ASK EC TO FIX PORTAL, DROP AADHAAR AUTHENTICATION · CONTINUED

As recently as October 13, the in-charge of the tribunals once again asked the EC to "fix the issue" to ensure proper functioning of the tribunals such that final orders can be uploaded, the records show. The judges also separately raised concerns with the Election Commission and the Calcutta High Court.

In fact, the matter came up once again on October 12 when the office of the CEO wrote to the tribunals' in-charge forwarding the request of an appellant for disposal of his appeal. The tribunal informed the CEO office on October 13 that: "Since the system at present does not allow the tribunals to upload the final order and in this regard, CEO has already been apprised of vide letter dt. 24.09.2026."

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Aadhaar authentication and the *Puttaswamy* limits on mandatory linkage; appellate machinery under the Representation of the People Act; the practical gap between a judicial remedy and the software that delivers it.

GS III · TECHNOLOGY & EMPLOYMENT

Microsoft offers buyouts to 60,000 workers in India, US, UK, Canada

Microsoft announced a voluntary exit programme for eligible employees in India, the US, the UK and Canada, offering financial support and career planning resources to those opting to leave the company. Globally, around **60,000 employees** are eligible.

It is learnt that eligible employees in India will have until **December 1** to decide on the voluntary exit offer. The package is understood to be similar to a standard severance arrangement, including one month's base salary for every completed year of service, along with health insurance and career transition services.

MICROSOFT OFFERS BUYOUTS TO 60,000 WORKERS IN INDIA, US, UK, CANADA · CONTINUED

Microsoft has about **23,000 employees in India**, although there is no immediate clarity on how many of them would be eligible for the voluntary exit programme. The offer will be available to employees at level 70 and below (internal job grades that span various levels of seniority at Microsoft) in participating teams across the four countries.

It is a time-limited initiative aimed at providing greater flexibility to employees considering opportunities outside the company, the company said, adding that it is "on track to fulfil our commitment of equipping 20 million people across India with AI skills by 2030".

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Technological unemployment and the AI transition in services; India's IT workforce and the skilling response; voluntary separation as a restructuring instrument. Pair with the Anthropic IPO item for the AI-and-jobs debate.

Polity & Governance

GS Paper II — elections, rights, institutions

THE BIG STORY · ELECTORAL ROLLS

'Nobody will be prosecuted': SC on deleted voters submitting Form 6

Chief Justice says the court will take care of the rest as petitioners argue that voters struck off the rolls in Maharashtra are being made to register afresh as new voters

The Supreme Court on Monday sought to allay fears that voters whose names were deleted from the electoral rolls during the Special Intensive Revision in Maharashtra and parts of Pune and Mumbai will be prosecuted for submitting Form 6 for re-entry.

"Nobody will be prosecuted," Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, presiding over a three-judge bench, remarked while hearing a petition challenging the SIR in Maharashtra.

Appearing for the petitioner, Senior Advocate Arvind Datar said that the Election Commission of India had asked deleted voters to submit Form 6 to register as fresh voters. He pointed out that **Form 6 is meant for first-time voters**; therefore, deleted voters filling it up may be committing an offence.

Datar said that in Maharashtra, **33 per cent of the voters had been struck off the rolls** and in parts of Pune and Mumbai, the figure is 40 per cent. He added that **1.22 crore names were deleted over logical discrepancies**.

He urged the court to direct the ECI not to finalise the rolls. "Let them not finalise the electoral roll now because Maharashtra does not have any immediate elections," he said, adding that "if 33 per cent people have been deleted, it may take some time to bring them back".

'You are a whistle-blower'. Issuing notice to the ECI, the CJI said, "You are a whistle-blower. You have come to us. We will take care of the rest of the (rest)".

PARLIAMENTS HAVE A RESPONSIBILITY TO LISTEN TO YOUNG VOICES: BIRLA · CONTINUED

Welcoming the BRICS parliamentary leaders, Birla said: "Parliaments had a vital responsibility to listen to young voices, understand their hopes and concerns, and create pathways through which their energy, creativity and capabilities could be channelled into nation-building."

He said youth are now equipped with growing access to quality education and technological knowledge, alongside an immense desire to innovate, excel and contribute to society. "The aspirations of the youth must be met with meaningful opportunities, dignity and an enabling environment in which their talents could flourish," he said.

'NOBODY WILL BE PROSECUTED': SC ON DELETED VOTERS SUBMITTING FORM 6 · CONTINUED

To a query from the bench, the counsel pointed out that Monday (October 26) is the last date for filing claims and objections and November 6 is the date for publishing the draft roll.

Datar requested the court to hear the matter before the draft is published. The CJI, however, said that if the court is convinced that there are people who still need time to submit their documents, it would issue appropriate directions.

Datar said that his apprehension was that the EC might not accept objections after the last date. The CJI asked, "How can they say… we have been extending the dates in all cases." Datar then urged the court to extend the dates for Maharashtra, too.

Redevelopment and the missing voter. He pointed out that "there are a lot of redevelopment projects in Mumbai and Pune. Old housing complexes are demolished and they are reconstructed. So, where 1,000 people are staying, they will get fresh flats and 2,000 new people will come. So, all these 1,000 people will be given accommodation in some other part of Mumbai. What they have done is they have said the person was not found and they completely deleted. So, **3,500 redevelopment projects in Mumbai alone and about 1,500 in Pune**. This is a peculiar problem to Maharashtra."

The bench, however, expressed reluctance in passing any *ex-parte* order. "Can your Lordships at least say that objections received after today will also be entertained," said Datar. The CJI said, "That will amount to extending the date." The court fixed November 5 to hear it next.

WHY IT MATTERS — Forms 6, 7 and 8 and the legal difference between fresh registration and restoration; urban redevelopment and transient residence as a cause of wrongful deletion; the Supreme Court's supervisory role over roll revision; the draft-roll timeline as the operative deadline.

GS II · RIGHTS OF THE ELDERLY

Keralam House passes Bill to protect senior citizens' rights

First State to bring a legal framework for the welfare of the elderly



Chief Minister V D Satheesan at the state Assembly in Thiruvananthapuram on Monday. PTI

WHAT THE LAW RECOGNISES

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM — The Chief Minister at the state Assembly on Monday. PTI

The Keralam Legislative Assembly passed on Monday the **Senior Citizens (Care and Protection of Rights) Bill, 2026**, India's first State-level legal framework aimed at elder welfare.

The Chief Minister, who piloted the Bill in the Assembly, said he considered the legislation "as the first realisation of the fact that our world is changing". "The changes taking place across the world due to demographic transition must be viewed seriously. We are living in an era when these demographic changes are becoming a threat even to nations across the world," he said.

For ageing Keralam, the law is a significant move — it envisages making elder care rights-based, regulated and professional.

GS II · RIGHT TO PROTEST & CAMPUS GOVERNANCE

'All demands not met': Jamia agrees to hold union polls after 20 yrs but protest continues

Scuffles and detentions continue as the strike enters its third week



Security personnel deployed outside the university on Monday; (left) protesters outside the varsity. ABHINAV SAHA/ TABSHIR SHAMS

NEW DELHI — Security personnel deployed outside the university on Monday. ABHINAV SAHA / TABSHIR SHAMS

The Jamia Millia Islamia university in Delhi on Monday agreed to hold student union elections, once the union's constitution receives official approval, in a bid to end a two-week-long hunger strike by five students. Hours after the announcement, however, a section of protesting students wrote to the Vice-Chancellor seeking a revision of the university's order, arguing that their demands have not been fully addressed.

Three of the five students, who have been fasting since **October 12**, have vowed to continue their strike.

"The Jamia Millia Islamia Student's Union (JMISU) election will be held after 15 days, from the date of approval of the constitution…," the order issued by the Registrar's office stated. But the order does not set a fixed timeline, which has been a key demand of the protesters.

GS II · PARLIAMENT & MULTILATERALISM

Parliaments have a responsibility to listen to young voices: Birla



PM Narendra Modi, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla and Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Harivansh with delegates attending the 12th BRICS Parliamentary Forum at the Parliament complex, Monday. PTI

NEW DELHI — The Prime Minister, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla and the Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman with delegates at the 12th BRICS Parliamentary Forum at the Parliament complex on Monday. PTI

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla said on Monday that Parliaments have the responsibility to "listen to young voices", underlining the importance of "harnessing the aspirations of the youth" in the process of nation-building.

"Their strength lay not merely in their Constitutional authority but also in their ability to foster constructive dialogue, build consensus, uphold transparency and remain steadfastly accountable to the citizens they represent," he said.

CONTINUED · CONTINUED

Calling for renewed commitment among BRICS member countries, the Speaker urged them to transform experience into joint action and dialogue into concrete and meaningful cooperation. The Speaker noted that the adoption of the joint statement at the BRICS Summit earlier this year marked a significant milestone. He said that BRICS had the added responsibility of amplifying the voice of the **Global South**.

The Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha highlighted the role of BRICS, saying it represents around **49.5% of the world's population**. The theme of the 12th edition of the BRICS Parliamentary Forum is **"Strengthening Parliaments for People-Centric Development"**.

WHY IT MATTERS — BRICS expansion and parliamentary diplomacy; the Global South as a diplomatic constituency; the demographic dividend framed as a governance obligation. Note the 49.5% figure and the forum theme — standard prelims fodder.

TN DEFECTIONS: SC JUNKS PLEA FOR CBI INVESTIGATION INTO 'HORSE-TRADING' · CONTINUED

The bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, was hearing a petition by an advocate who alleged that the "acts" of the MLAs "are not only corrupt practice but against the mandate of the crores of innocent and responsible citizens".

The plea filed through an advocate alleged that the MLAs "had submitted their resignation on 25.05.2026 to the Assembly Speaker and immediately within half an hour they joined the TVK… in front of Tamil Nadu secretariat itself".

KERALAM HOUSE PASSES BILL TO PROTECT SENIOR CITIZENS' RIGHTS · CONTINUED

A major highlight is that it recognises a senior citizen's ability to live safely and independently in their home, with institutional care being the last resort. The Bill also recognises a living will — a declaration of a senior citizen's choices and preferences regarding end-of-life situations. A senior citizen can execute a will stating their choices regarding intensive-care admission, invasive tubes and other life-sustaining medical interventions.

It gives priority to vulnerable senior women, including widows, abandoned people, people with disabilities, survivors of violence, and homeless or destitute women.

Among other things, it envisages senior-friendly public spaces, including ramps, priority seating and queues, and accessible washrooms. The concept of care and welfare has been expanded beyond food, clothing, shelter and medical treatment to social services, recreation, and participation in spiritual, social and cultural activities.

The regulatory system. All care centres, retirement homes, hospices, agencies and caregiver training centres will have prescribed standards, ensure social and recreational opportunities, and protect residents from abuse and exploitation. The Bill proposes the establishment of the **Keralam Geriatric Care Certification Framework** to provide progressive certification for caregivers, specifying a training curriculum and requiring background verification of caregivers, including mandatory police clearance for those deployed in senior citizen care centres or providing live-in care to a senior citizen living alone.

The Bill also envisages penal provisions for running an unregistered centre: obstructing the Act's implementation can result in up to two years' imprisonment and a fine of up to **₹25,000**. Illegal possession of a resident's property, abuse or cruelty, and abandonment can each attract up to three years' imprisonment and a fine of up to ₹50,000. Failure to report suspected abuse when required can attract a fine of up to ₹10,000. Offences are cognisable and bailable.

WHY IT MATTERS — Demographic transition and population ageing; the Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act, 2007 and what a State law adds; living wills after *Common Cause* (2018) on passive euthanasia; rights-based versus welfare-based framing. A strong, concrete GS I/II example.

'ALL DEMANDS NOT MET': JAMIA AGREES TO HOLD UNION POLLS AFTER 20 YRS BUT PROTEST CONTINUES · CONTINUED

The varsity's latest order also gives students two other assurances, including revocation of suspension and show-cause notices issued to them during the protest. It also says that a committee will be constituted to inquire into the actions of security staff during the protest.

Protesters' contention. The primary demand of protesters has been setting a fixed timeline for restoring the JMISU, which has remained dissolved **since 2006**. The protesters also demanded the revocation of disciplinary actions initiated against participating students and an official inquiry into the conduct of university security personnel.

They have also demanded the withdrawal of all disciplinary action, including show-cause notices, suspensions, campus bans and rustication, and the resignation of the Chief Security Advisor.

Students have sought a formal commitment that the union constitution will be drafted and approved by **December 20**, followed by an election notification within 15 days.

WHY IT MATTERS — The Lyngdoh Committee recommendations and the legal status of student union elections; Article 19(1)(a) and (b) on campus; university autonomy versus democratic participation; administrative measures used against protest.

'TRANSFER' OF VOTES IN GOA FROM ONE SEAT TO ANOTHER: PROBE SAYS NO PROOF OF ILLEGALITY · CONTINUED

The complaint alleged that more than 50 voters from Curtorim were "unlawfully migrated" to the electoral roll of Fatorda, while retaining their original house numbers.

The probe report says that no application for deletion of any names for the Fatorda electoral roll has been filed by any political party since 2017; the report says this holds true for even the recently concluded Special Intensive Revision.

In the 2022 Assembly elections in the state, Fatorda had been the only seat won by the Goa Forward Party, which contested the election in alliance with the Congress. Of these, 31 applications were accepted by the Electoral Registration Officer, Fatorda, while the remaining were rejected.

The report adds that the records "indicate that the inclusion of these 31 electors in Fatorda… was preceded by the submission and processing of Form 6 applications", and says that copies of these applications are available in the office of the Electoral Registration Officer, Fatorda.

WHY IT MATTERS — Summary versus intensive revision; Form 6 and Form 7 as the only lawful routes for addition and deletion; the burden of proof in allegations of roll manipulation. A useful counterweight to the deletion-focused stories.

GS II · ANTI-DEFECTION

TN defections: SC junks plea for CBI investigation into 'horse-trading'

The Supreme Court on Monday rejected a plea seeking a CBI probe into "horse-trading" charges against a Tamil Nadu Minister and the general secretary of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) and four AIADMK MLAs who had resigned from the Assembly and joined the TVK.

"We are not inclined to entertain this writ petition. The same is, accordingly, dismissed with liberty to the petitioner to avail appropriate remedy in accordance with law," a three-judge bench presided over by CJI Surya Kant said.

Six AIADMK legislators had resigned from the Assembly and joined the ruling TVK. All of them had been elected on AIADMK tickets in the Assembly polls.

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The petitioner contended that if the MLAs had any "personal reasons or difference of opinion with the party after the election, they should have resigned before voting in the floor test or they should have abstained from voting against the whip in the floor test. Instead of that, they actively and consciously voted in favour of TVK and immediately resigned as MLAs, and they immediately joined…TVK".

The plea urged the court to exercise powers under **Article 142** of the Constitution "to frame specific rules for preventing who is trading after elections with regard to the candidates either resigned or disqualified by the Parliament either when the law or rules in this regard".

WHY IT MATTERS — The Tenth Schedule and resignation as a route around disqualification; Article 142 and the limits of judicially framed rules; the cost and legitimacy of byelections triggered by defection.

GS II · JUDICIAL APPOINTMENTS

Justice P Sam Koshy recommended as Delhi HC Chief Justice by SC Collegium

The Supreme Court on Monday, during its collegium meeting, recommended the elevation of the Telangana High Court Acting Chief Justice P Sam Koshy as the Chief Justice of the Delhi High Court.

The Delhi High Court is currently operating under an Acting Chief Justice since its incumbent Chief Justice was elevated to the Supreme Court on October 6.

GS II · ELECTORAL ROLLS

‘Transfer’ of votes in Goa from one seat to another: probe says no proof of illegality



Vijai Sardesai alleged that over 50 voters from Curtorim were transferred to his constituency Fatorda, which he won by less than 1,600 votes in 2022

plaint with the CEO's office

PANAJI — The GFP chief alleged that over 50 voters from Curtorim were transferred to his constituency Fatorda, which he won by less than 1,600 votes in 2022.

A preliminary inquiry ordered by the Chief Electoral Officer has found no basis in allegations that some voters were “illegally transferred” from Curtorim Assembly constituency to Fatorda seat in South Goa.

As per the inquiry report, voters were added to the Fatorda electoral roll after the processing of Form 6 applications for inclusion — as per the prescribed legal procedures — during the Special Summary Revision exercise in the state in 2017. Moreover, says the preliminary inquiry, since 2017, no Form 7 application seeking deletion of any names has been filed by any political party.

JUSTICE P SAM KOSHY RECOMMENDED AS DELHI HC CHIEF JUSTICE BY SC COLLEGIUM · CONTINUED

Justice Koshy is currently serving as Acting Chief Justice of the Telangana High Court after its Chief Justice was elevated to the top court on October 6. Justice Koshy, who is at the 13th place in the all-India seniority list of the high court judges, is set to retire in April 2029.

He started his legal career in Madhya Pradesh High Court at Jabalpur, his practice broadly involved civil, constitutional, service and labour matters. He subsequently practised at the Chhattisgarh High Court at Bilaspur from 2001 until 2013, where he was also the government advocate. He was appointed as an additional judge of the Chhattisgarh High Court, his parent high court, in September 2013, and was made a permanent judge in 2016. He was transferred to the Telangana High Court in July 2023.

WHY IT MATTERS — The Collegium system and the Memorandum of Procedure; transfer and elevation of High Court judges; the all-India seniority list. Judicial appointments are a standing GS II theme.

Governance, Defence & Security GS Papers II and III

EXPLAINED · GS II POLITY & RIGHTS

Census duty: government’s powers and private citizens’ rights

‘Any person’ the government considers suitable can be asked to perform the duties of an enumerator. But the rules are not as absolute as this sounds

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LARGE WORKFORCE — Census enumerators at work in New Delhi. Census remains overwhelmingly manpower-intensive despite digitisation; recent operational figures put the number of enumerators and supervisors being trained at around 31 lakh. FILE

The Centre earlier this month amended the **Census Rules, 1990** to expressly state that teachers of government, local authority, aided as well as unaided private educational institutions may be appointed as Census enumerators. It similarly included officials of establishments such as banks, companies, institutions, societies and trusts.

But the amendment also retains a much wider category: **“any person”** whom a State government or Union Territory administration considers suitable to perform the duties of an enumerator.

This is not very different from what the rules said before the amendment. The earlier rules already said an enumerator could be chosen from among “Teachers, Clerks or any official or any person”. If “any person” literally meant anybody, private-school teachers and private-sector employees were already covered.

What is the significance of the amendment? Officials in the Ministry of Home Affairs say it has been done to remove any ambiguity from the rules and make sure that the Census operation, which requires lakhs of enumerators, is conducted smoothly. However, there is a backdrop.

On May 22, the Bombay High Court gave interim protection to associations representing more than 500 private unaided and minority schools in Maharashtra. It said Section 4A of the Census Act imposed an obligation on local authorities, while Sections 6 and 7 did not, in its preliminary view, confer authority to compulsorily requisition teaching and non-teaching staff of private unaided schools.

It then considered the old Rule 3, which permitted “Teachers, Clerks or any official or any person” to be enumerators. The government had argued that this was broad enough to include private teachers. The court rejected that interpretation at the interim stage. It observed that if “any person” were given an unrestricted meaning, it could extend to private professionals such as doctors, advocates and chartered accountants. It held, *prima facie*, that subordinate legislation could not travel beyond its parent statute.

The operative order restrained authorities from issuing further orders “compelling or requiring teachers and/or employees” of the petitioner schools to perform Census duties. Then on October 8, the Punjab and Haryana High Court stayed Haryana government communications seeking details of private unaided school teachers for Census duty. Eight days later came the amendment.

What does the Census Act actually say? Section 4(2) of the Census Act, 1948 gives the state government power to “appoint persons as census-officers” to take, aid in or supervise the Census within a specified area. Importantly, it adds that such persons, “when so appointed, shall be bound to serve accordingly”.

CENSUS DUTY: GOVERNMENT'S POWERS AND PRIVATE CITIZENS' RIGHTS · CONTINUED

This is potentially the strongest basis for the government's case. Unlike provisions dealing specifically with government employees, **Section 4 uses the broad word "persons"**. But other provisions of the Act are much more specific about whose services can be compulsorily called upon.

Section 4A requires a local authority, when directed by the Centre, to make available such staff as are necessary for Census work. **Sections 6 and 7** also permit assistance to be sought from private establishments and their personnel — but in defined circumstances relating primarily to counting people under their charge or present in those establishments.

For example, **Section 7** allows the District Magistrate to call upon staff of a factory or establishment to assist with the Census of persons present in its premises. It does not expressly say that such employees can be taken out of that establishment and deployed generally as door-to-door enumerators.

So, can private individuals be compelled to serve as enumerators? In 2010, LIC challenged an order requiring its Jalandhar office to provide at least 150 employees as Enumerators and Supervisors. The Punjab and Haryana High Court quashed the orders. It held that Section 7(c) only allowed assistance in taking the Census of persons within an establishment and found the directions "beyond the scope and powers conferred by the Census Act, 1948". But it expressly left the state free to invoke Section 4(2) "wherever and whenever so required".

In a separate LIC case, the Gujarat High Court similarly ruled against requisition of LIC employees, with a Division Bench holding in 2019 that Section 7 did not confer such a power. That judgment is under challenge before the Supreme Court.

Does the Constitution allow citizens to be compulsorily drafted for public work? Yes — but this does not by itself give Census authorities the power to do so. **Article 23(1)** prohibits *begaar* and other forms of forced labour. But **Article 23(2)** expressly permits the State to impose "compulsory service for public purposes", provided it does not discriminate on specified grounds.

Under the Police Act, 1861, residents of a neighbourhood may in specified circumstances be appointed special police officers. The Calcutta High Court in *Dulal Samanta v District Magistrate, Howrah* (1958) characterised this as compulsory public service protected by Article 23(2).

An even clearer example is the **National Service Act, 1972**, under which specified qualified doctors and engineers can be called up for national service. However, Parliament created an elaborate statutory regime for this: it identified who was liable, provided for registration and notice, permitted postponement on hardship grounds, prescribed remuneration and required private employers to release — and later reinstate — employees called up for service. **The same elaborate arrangement is not available in the Census Act.**

WHY IT MATTERS — Article 23 and the distinction between forced labour and compulsory public service; delegated legislation that cannot travel beyond its parent statute; the Census Act, 1948 (Sections 4, 4A, 6, 7) and the Census Rules, 1990. A model GS II answer on the limits of executive power — and an unusually clean illustration of the *ultra vires* doctrine.

GS III · INTERNAL SECURITY

Drones to multi-role helicopters: Govt clears ₹2.12-lakh crore defence procurement



NEW DELHI — The Defence Minister inspects an indigenous thermal imaging system during the 'Swavlamban 2026' seminar on Monday. ANI

In a major defence acquisition push, the government on Monday cleared procurement of a range of military platforms and weapon systems, including light multi-role helicopters, long-range Kamikaze drones and radars, at a cost of **₹2.12 lakh crore**, to boost the combat prowess of the defence forces.

The procurement proposals were approved by the **Defence Acquisition Council (DAC)**, the defence ministry's highest decision-making body on military procurement. It was chaired by the Defence Minister.

The DAC accorded **Acceptance of Necessity (AoN)**, or in-principle administrative approval, to various capital acquisition proposals of an estimated cost of about ₹2,12,000 crore, the defence ministry said.

DRONES TO MULTI-ROLE HELICOPTERS: GOVT CLEARS ₹2.12-LAKH CRORE DEFENCE PROCUREMENT · CONTINUED

For the Indian Army, approval was accorded for the procurement of high mobility vehicles (HMVs), self-propelled tracked gun systems (GSRS), light multi-role helicopters (LMRH), very short-range air defence systems (VSHORADS) and counter unmanned aerial systems (C-UAS). The DAC also cleared the acquisition of other unmanned aerial systems, surveillance aerial vehicles, integrated surveillance and strike systems and long-range Kamikaze drone systems.

While the HMVs are expected to enhance operational capabilities, logistical support and mobility in challenging terrains, the self-propelled tracked gun system will provide mobility and firepower for mechanised formations. The GSRS will serve as a force multiplier, providing real-time situational awareness.

For the Indian Navy, approval was given for the procurement of **Active Off-board Decoy System (AODS)** and other major naval platforms. The AODS will enhance the credibility of anti-missile defence, especially against modern anti-ship missiles of adversaries. The indigenously designed and constructed major naval platforms will possess modern-day warfare capabilities.

Out of the total AoNs accorded, approximately **82 per cent of the procurements will be made from the Indian industry**.

WHY IT MATTERS — The DAC and the Acceptance of Necessity stage of the Defence Acquisition Procedure; indigenisation under Atmanirbhar Bharat; loitering munitions and counter-drone systems as emerging capability areas. Learn the acronyms: AoN, VSHORADS, C-UAS, AODS, LMRH.

GS III · DEFENCE TECHNOLOGY

'Aatmanirbharta 2.0': Rajnath calls for top-end, state-of-the-art defence tech

Minister says innovators will play the role of 'impact players'

The Defence Minister on Monday said India's bid to achieve *aatmanirbharta* (self-reliance) in defence is entering the "second phase" and called on all associated stakeholders to develop top-end and state-of-the-art technologies in the sector.

In his address at the plenary session of the Indian Navy's annual seminar 'Swavlamban 2026', the Minister underlined the need to indigenously manufacture products that are "cost-effective, operationally superior and globally competitive".

While calling for 'Aatmanirbharta 2.0' in the defence sector, he emphasised on strengthening **research and development**, building resilient supply chains to cut import dependence and achieving technological superiority, thus contributing to the vision of **Viksit Bharat by 2047**.

‘AATMANIRBHARTA 2.0’: RAJNATH CALLS FOR TOP-END, STATE-OF-THE-ART DEFENCE TECH · CONTINUED

He asserted that the progress achieved so far has created a “strong foundation” for the next phase, which must focus on advanced technologies and objectives that are considered difficult to achieve.

He emphasised the need to build on the gains of the first phase of self-reliance, and said defence innovators with futuristic vision and scientific discipline would play the role of “impact players” in pursuing more challenging technological goals in the next phase.

Addressing the plenary session, the Navy Chief pitched for accelerating the pace of translating innovation into operational capabilities for the naval force, and said that since its construction is capital-intensive, there is a need to explore ways to “reduce costs” while expanding domestic production. He also called for development of a **‘Dual Technology Roadmap’** to identify and prioritise technologies that can serve both civilian and military requirements.

WHY IT MATTERS — Defence indigenisation and the iDEX/Swavlamban innovation ecosystem; dual-use technology policy; defence R&D spending as a share of the budget. Useful vocabulary for a GS III answer on self-reliance.

GS II · FEDERALISM & BORDER MANAGEMENT

China claims it is strictly abiding by pacts with India

Days after the Indo-Tibetan Border Police Director General talked about face-offs between Indian and Chinese troops at multiple locations in Arunachal Pradesh, and that the situation continues, Beijing — in its first official comments after the statement — on Monday said it is strictly abiding by the relevant agreements with India and conducts normal border patrols to safeguard its sovereignty.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) had said on Friday that friction points typically occur when Chinese forces depart from established patrolling patterns in border pockets.

Responding to this, a Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson said at a media briefing, “China strictly abides by the relevant agreements and common understandings reached between the two countries, and conducts normal border patrol and control activities to safeguard its territorial sovereignty and stability in the border areas.”

CHINA CLAIMS IT IS STRICTLY ABIDING BY PACTS WITH INDIA · CONTINUED

He said China and India maintain communication through diplomatic and military channels. “We hope that India will work with China in the same direction by jointly implementing the common understandings reached between the two sides and maintaining peace and tranquillity in the border areas with concrete actions,” he said.

Last week, an MEA spokesperson said the situation along the **Line of Actual Control** is disturbed from time to time when Chinese forces diverge from established patrolling patterns, asserting that the maintenance of peace and tranquillity in the border areas is essential for the overall development of bilateral relations.

On September 6, the Corps Commander-level talks were held at the Wacha-Damai border meeting point on the Indian side to address ongoing issues along the LAC in the area. Last month, the Prime Minister held bilateral talks with the Chinese President on the margins of the BRICS summit.

WHY IT MATTERS — The LAC and the border agreements of 1993, 1996 and 2005; patrolling patterns and the disengagement framework after Galwan; WMCC and Corps Commander-level mechanisms. Standing GS II material on India–China.

International Relations General Studies Paper II

THE LEAD · LATIN AMERICA

In blow to Latin America’s Right, Brazil’s Lula wins again; Bolsonaro rejects result

Presidential poll verdict a snub for Trump, who had embraced the Bolsonaro family and the region’s rising Right; Lula wins 51.8% of the vote versus 48.2% for his rival



SAO PAULO — Brazil’s President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva addresses supporters after his victory in the presidential runoff election, at Paulista Avenue, in Sao Paulo on Monday. REUTERS

Brazilian voters on Sunday handed the leftist President, Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, a fourth term in office and a surprise victory over Flávio Bolsonaro, his right-wing challenger, in a striking rebuke to a conservative surge sweeping Latin America.

Bolsonaro refused to accept the outcome and said it was the result of foul play, increasing the risk of unrest over the election result. The rejection by voters of the president, son of a former president jailed for attempting a coup four years ago, is also a loss for President Donald Trump, who embraced the Bolsonaro family and the region’s rising right.

Lula, in contrast to many world leaders, has often and deeply clashed with Trump, and his victory highlights that Latin America’s left-wing forces still wield influence despite a string of losses across the hemisphere.

“I would like to thank the Brazilian people for the generosity they have shown me for a long time,” Lula said during a victory speech in São Paulo, flanked by his wife, running mate and allies.

The result capped a chaotic final stretch of the race, as polling places were ordered to remain open after public transportation delays and torrential rains disrupted voting. The extended polling hours, which both candidates asked for but came right as voting was set to conclude, opened up the possibility that results would be disputed.

GS II · EUROPE

After Vucic defeat, Serbia waits to see how student-backed leaders will govern



Supporters of the ‘Student List – Students Win’ outside Parliament after Aleksandar Vucic conceded defeat in the parliamentary election, in Belgrade on Monday. REUTERS

After Vucic defeat.

BELGRADE — Supporters of the ‘Student List — Students Win’ outside Parliament after Aleksandar Vucic conceded defeat in the parliamentary election, on Monday. REUTERS

Serbia woke to a new era on Monday after a student-backed protest movement unseated long-time leader Aleksandar Vucic in a historic landslide election that sparked nationwide celebrations, although few had an idea of how they would govern.

Tens of thousands took to the streets of Belgrade and other cities and towns across Serbia after Vucic conceded defeat late on Sunday, capping two years of peaceful anti-government protests calling for the populist ruler to step down.

IN BLOW TO LATIN AMERICA'S RIGHT, BRAZIL'S LULA WINS AGAIN; BOLSONARO REJECTS RESULT · CONTINUED

Bolsonaro called an order by Brazil's judiciary to extend voting a "dirty trick" and demanded the election be annulled. "There's a lot that needs to be cleared up before Brazil simply accepts this foul play that took place in these elections," he said in Brasilia, the capital.

Bolsonaro's party will now likely petition electoral authorities for a review of the result.

Lula headed into Sunday's vote as the underdog, trailing by 2 percentage points behind his opponent in the first round of voting earlier this month. But on Sunday, he achieved a stunning comeback, winning **51.8% of the vote versus 48.2%** for Bolsonaro, with nearly all the ballots counted. Lula's margin of victory on Sunday was roughly double the margin four years ago when he narrowly defeated Bolsonaro's father.

It was the first time in Brazil's history that a candidate who lost the first round came back to win the second. Lula's victory was even more surprising given that several of the candidates who failed to make it out of the first round were conservatives whose votes were expected to broadly shift to Bolsonaro.

'Win halts shift to Right'. The stunning triumph of leftist incumbent Lula over Bolsonaro on Sunday, with 51.8 per cent of the vote to 48.2 per cent, limits President Trump's drive to tighten his grip on the Western Hemisphere and cements Latin America's most populous country and largest economy as a counterweight to Washington. A Bolsonaro victory would have left Mexico's Claudia Sheinbaum as the only progressive president among the region's powerhouses.

For the Trump administration, the defeat deprives Washington of a potential partner that had wielded sanctions and military force to reassert its dominance in the region. Lula's victory complicates its campaign to enlist Brazil in its military coalition against cartels and to gain preferential access to the country's critical minerals.

WHY IT MATTERS — Hemispheric realignment and the limits of great-power influence; BRICS cohesion and Brazil's role in it; election denial as a transnational phenomenon; critical minerals as a strategic prize. India's stake lies in BRICS, IBSA and climate diplomacy.

EXPLAINED · GS II

How Lula scripted the turnaround in Brazil, and what lies ahead

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Lula holds a copy of Brazil's Constitution during a rally. AP

In a stunning upset, Brazil's leftist President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva was re-elected for a historic fourth term on Sunday, securing **51.79% of the vote** against his rival Flávio Bolsonaro.

In the first round of voting earlier this month, he finished behind Flávio, the son of former President Jair Bolsonaro, whom Lula defeated in 2022. Flávio has called for annulling the results.

The verdict was historic for another reason: **since Brazil returned to direct presidential elections in 1989, no candidate who finished second in the first round had gone on to win the runoff.**

How did Lula emerge victorious? Two factors were key.

1. Higher turnout and voter mobilisation. Lula's narrow loss to Bolsonaro in the first round initially dismayed his supporters but prompted renewed mobilisation. Young Brazilians organised nationwide demonstrations, while right-wing candidates winning the last seven consecutive presidential elections across Latin America initially dismayed his supporters. The 80-year-old president, who does not own a mobile phone, also stepped up his digital campaign.

GS II · ISRAEL

Netanyahu denies reports of pre-poll strikes on Iran; 'my eyes on you' says rival

Israelis entered the final 24 hours of an intense election season on Monday, as reports circulated that the Prime Minister may have clashed with the Israeli military over initiating a possible escalation with Iran immediately before elections.

Tensions flared over reports that the Prime Minister and his military chief of staff clashed over an instruction by the PM to carry out an "action" the army worried could reignite the conflict with Iran. The main rival, a former military chief of staff, warned that he was not to "dare to place your own political interests above the security of the state". He posted on X: "Netanyahu, my eyes are on you."

CONTINUED · CONTINUED

"Campaigns using AI-influence training are now a reality that we face and it will be ubiquitous by the 2028 cycle," said a managing partner of an AI consultancy. "The public increasingly cannot and will not be able to discern what is created by systems like Claude and ChatGPT versus human-originated content," another said.

The firm would buy placements on high-authority websites that AI models already cite. The New York-based creative strategy firm has worked with companies and political campaigns.

WHY IT MATTERS — Generative AI and electoral integrity; search-engine optimisation evolving into AI-answer optimisation; transparency and disclosure norms for political advertising. A sharp, current example for essays on technology and democracy.

AFTER VUCIC DEFEAT, SERBIA WAITS TO SEE HOW STUDENT-BACKED LEADERS WILL GOVERN · CONTINUED

With almost **99% of votes counted**, the students' candidates had secured a commanding **52.7% of the vote**, according to the State Election Commission, versus **39.2%** for Vucic's Serbia Progressive Party. That gives the students **139 seats in the 250-seat parliament**, leaving the SNS with 97, and the remainder held by minority parties.

The students' win marks a profound political shift in the country of some six million people and is reminiscent of the defeat of Hungary's Viktor Orban in April.

It may also offer inspiration to other student movements that have cropped up across Europe in recent weeks demanding better education standards and prospects. However, the movement, with candidates including university professors, actors and farmers, has no clear leaders, and it is unclear who will act as prime minister or to other key positions on the students' domestic agenda, which aims to root out corruption.

"I thought it was unbelievable, I still do not believe it. It was too long, and (Vucic) was pressuring us for a long, long time," said a university administrator.

WHY IT MATTERS — Civic and student movements as agents of democratic change; the 2024 Novi Sad canopy collapse as an accountability trigger; EU accession politics in the Western Balkans; the governance challenge facing leaderless movements.

GS II · WEST ASIA

Mecca pact states push for peace in Iran as Houthis ramp up strikes

Top officials from Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Pakistan met Iranian officials in Tehran on Monday in a bid to de-escalate the West Asian conflict, as Yemen's Houthis stepped up attacks on Saudi Arabia and Egypt approved defence support for the Gulf kingdom.

The talks were the first high-level contact between Iran and the three nations, which signed the **Mecca mutual defence pact in August**, since a war that began with US and Israeli strikes on Iran also spread to Saudi Arabia and Yemen. The Saudi Foreign Ministry said the visit was intended to open negotiating channels to "prevent the return of military escalation".

Saudi Arabia was represented by Defence Minister Prince Khalid bin Salman, younger brother of the Crown Prince; Pakistan by army chief Field Marshal Asim Munir; and Turkey by its intelligence chief. Iranian officials said that at the conclusion of the meetings, the four states agreed to continue talks with a view to strengthening cooperation, especially in peace and security, state media reported.

HOW LULA SCRIPTED THE TURNAROUND IN BRAZIL, AND WHAT LIES AHEAD · CONTINUED

He also announced welfare measures, including increased and early payments under a cash-transfer programme, and secured congressional approval for a shorter working week, reducing the maximum from 44 to 40 hours without cutting pay.

Brazil's Superior Electoral Court reported that nearly **three million more Brazilians voted in the runoff**. Although it is unclear how they voted, their number exceeded the gap of just over 2.2 million votes between Lula and Bolsonaro in the first round.

2. Strongholds retained, gains elsewhere. Lula won all nine states in the country's northeast, his traditional vote base. But his victory depended on gains in areas that earlier favoured Bolsonaro.

What is the broader significance? Flávio's challenge to the election result has revived tensions over the democratic transfer of power. During the last elections in 2022, Jair Bolsonaro refused to accept the result, leading to his supporters attempting to storm government buildings in Brasilia.

Lula used these interventions to frame the election partly around Brazil's resistance to foreign pressure. Lula's re-election leaves Washington dealing with a Brazilian government that has resisted its expanding military and security role in Latin America.

WHY IT MATTERS — Runoff systems and turnout mobilisation; welfare transfers and electoral behaviour; the democratic transfer of power as a contested norm; Brazil's most conservative Congress since the 1980s as a constraint on the executive.

GS II · CHINA

Xi opens Communist Party plenum, aims at tightening discipline

China's Communist Party began a meeting of senior cadres on Monday aimed at tightening discipline and pressing officials to implement Beijing's orders, paving the way for a leadership reshuffle next year expected to extend the President's rule for another five years.

The President briefed the party's four-day Central Committee meeting on a draft document centred on "full and rigorous party self-governance" that state news agency Xinhua said addressed the challenges the party faced, including growing its governing capacity, as well as guarding against complacency and combating corruption — the President's signature campaign.

"The implementation of major decisions and plans of the Central Committee, the party's central decision-making bodies, must not be empty rhetoric," the *Xinhua* commentary read.

XI OPENS COMMUNIST PARTY PLENUM, AIMS AT TIGHTENING DISCIPLINE · CONTINUED

"It is essential to both refine institutional rules and regulations to close loopholes and strengthen safeguards, and ensure their effective implementation," it said.

The Central Committee will convene in the closed-door meeting from Monday to Thursday — the fifth such gathering since the current cohort was formed in 2022 and therefore known as the **"fifth plenum"**.

"The plenum will present the President as in control, and able to continue his command," said the director of a China institute. "It is likely everything will be centred on him, to dispel any rumours or doubts about his physical fitness and ability to continue in his role."

WHY IT MATTERS — Party-state structure in China: Central Committee, plenums and the Politburo; the anti-corruption campaign as a political instrument; leadership succession and its implications for India's neighbourhood.

AHEAD OF US MIDTERMS, CANDIDATES SEEK TO GET AI CHATBOT 'SUPPORT' · CONTINUED

One presentation proposed a strategy for a Republican challenger in a governor's race. It aimed to convince ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini and other chatbots to present him as the preferred choice on key issues, and went well beyond traditional search-engine optimisation that candidates have used for years.

Fees can range from hundreds of dollars a month for AI monitoring jobs to tens of thousands per month if consulting and buying media are included. The presentation proposed that the campaign should create hundreds of AI-friendly policy pages and citations across the websites frequently cited by AI chatbots. It proposed ways to track how major chatbots respond to political questions, and systematically alter content until the answers reflect the candidate's platform.

GS III · TECHNOLOGY & DEMOCRACY

Ahead of US midterms, candidates seek to get AI chatbot 'support'



NEW JERSEY — A person walks in front of a polling station on the first day of early voting. REUTERS

US political candidates have been engineering their campaign messages to appeal to the AI chatbots that more voters have been using to answer questions about issues, and documents reviewed by *Reuters* have revealed some of their strategies.

As AI increasingly becomes a source of news, political campaigns must make greater efforts to control output and become its recommendation when voters ask questions such as who is best on issues like taxes, housing and public safety.

MECCA PACT STATES PUSH FOR PEACE IN IRAN AS HOUTHIS RAMP UP STRIKES · CONTINUED

Pakistan and Qatar have led mediation efforts in the war. Qatari mediators were in Tehran on Sunday, an official told Reuters.

Egypt Parliament nod to defending Saudi. On Monday, the Houthis said they had attacked pumping stations on Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline as well as Riyadh airport. There was no immediate Saudi confirmation of the Houthi attacks.

The parliament in Egypt, which has said it is considering joining the Mecca pact, on Monday authorised the Egyptian military to help defend Saudi Arabia, a major financial and political partner for Cairo.

An Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson said that discussions would include "Israel's expansionist policies, developments in the Palestinian territories and Lebanon, and the repercussions of US and Israeli military action against Iran".

WHY IT MATTERS — Regional security architecture outside Western mediation; the Mecca mutual defence pact as a new bloc; Pakistan's military as a regional actor; the East-West pipeline as a Hormuz bypass. Direct implications for India's energy security and Gulf diaspora.

NETANYAHU DENIES REPORTS OF PRE-POLL STRIKES ON IRAN; 'MY EYES ON YOU' SAYS RIVAL · CONTINUED

A member of the opposition bloc sent a letter to Israel's attorney general demanding a criminal investigation into possible treason by the Prime Minister's "attempts to drag Israel into a war on the eve of elections, including a willingness to sacrifice (Israeli) soldiers out of fear of losing the election".

The Defence Minister also quickly denied the report. "I state unequivocally that there has been no intention of initiating an attack on Iran before the elections in Israel," he wrote on X on Monday, calling reports of rifts between political and military leaders "completely baseless and false". However, he stressed that Israel would respond forcefully if Iran attacks first.

WHY IT MATTERS — Civil–military relations and the political use of force; electoral timing and conflict behaviour; the Knesset's 120 seats and coalition arithmetic. Read with the Ideas-page analysis on what an Israeli election can and cannot change.

Economy, Trade & Industry

General Studies Paper III

₹2.12 lakh cr
Capital acquisition proposals cleared by the Defence Acquisition Council; 82% to be sourced from Indian industry.

60,000
Employees globally offered voluntary exit by Microsoft across India, the US, the UK and Canada.

$450 mn
To be invested by Tata Communications in a 10,000-km AI "super highway" of low-latency fibre across India.

50 % of GDP
Target to which the Union Finance Minister says the Centre is committed to capping the national debt by 2030.

34.6 %
All-India female labour force participation rate in September, against 77.4% for men — the gap the new ASUSE survey aims to explain.

LEAD · GS III ECONOMY

Russian crude purchases may fall in November as West Asia oil viability improves: BPCL

Russian oil has lost its price advantage as freight costs and supplier premiums rise; the country's second-largest public sector refiner expects to turn more to the Middle East

The country's second-largest public sector refiner Bharat Petroleum Corporation (BPCL) expects crude oil purchases from Russia to fall in November due to Russian crude's poor commercial viability — specifically elevated freight costs and high supplier premiums — compared to West Asian oil, whose availability and commercial viability have been improving in recent months, according to the company's Director (Finance).

"Our spot crude share remained at around **67% in Q2 (July-September)** while Russian grades accounted for approximately **37% of our total crude procurement**, both broadly in line with the previous quarter. As flows from the Middle East improved, we are progressively restored sourcing from the region while retaining the flexibility and diversification we had built during Q1," he said in an investor call that followed BPCL's September-quarter earnings.

He added that Russian oil volumes came down slightly in October from July-September levels, but will be down significantly in November due to commercial viability issues.

Discounts narrow. "November Russian volumes have come down compared to PG (Persian Gulf) grades. PG grades are actually more commercially viable compared to Russian grades and that is the reason November Russian (oil purchases) will be lesser," he said, without elaborating on volumes. Premiums for Russian crude were at **$12-13 per barrel in October**, but have now narrowed to about **$1-$2 a barrel** for December cargoes, he said.

For over four years, Russian oil has been available at a discount to other crudes, but amid global supply tightness and surging freight costs due to geopolitical crises, Russian oil has commanded a premium in recent months.

GS III · DIGITAL INFRASTRUCTURE

Tata Comms to invest $450 mn in AI super highway

Tata Communications on Monday announced strategic investments of close to **$450 million (around ₹4,375 crore)** to build an AI super highway in India — a high-speed, low-latency network fabric connecting India's key AI data-centre corridors.

The company will build around **10,000 kilometres** of the new long-haul fibre across India, creating one of the largest AI-ready connectivity corridors.

GS III · ENERGY & TRANSPORT

Govt notifies E100 as auto fuel — only for flex-fuel vehicles, not others

The amendment allows flex-fuel vehicles to run on up to 100% or nearly pure ethanol

Amid the ongoing debate over the use of E20 fuel, the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways on Monday notified a key change in the **Central Motor Vehicle Rules**, allowing flex-fuel vehicles to run on up to E100 or nearly pure ethanol. **This does not mean that every petrol car can use E100 now.**

The new regulation expands the range of fuels that can be used in vehicles and paves the way for the manufacturing and supply of more flex-fuel vehicle components, ethanol production infrastructure, and the deployment of such vehicles on the road.

The Ministry said that vehicles designed as flex-fuel vehicles will not have material compatibility issues with E100. It also said that **E85 or E100 shall be used in vehicles designed by the original equipment manufacturers as flex-fuel vehicles**. This means that the vehicles that use normal fuel or E20 cannot use E100.

GOVT NOTIFIES E100 AS AUTO FUEL — ONLY FOR FLEX-FUEL VEHICLES, NOT OTHERS · CONTINUED

"Flex-fuel vehicles are specifically designed with fuel-system components and materials that are compatible with ethanol blends from E20 to E100. Vehicles designed as flex-fuel vehicles will not have material compatibility issues. Motorists should check the fuel compatibility sticker on their vehicle and follow the manufacturer's guidance in the owner's manual while opting for the fuel choice at the fuel station," said the Ministry in its explanatory note on the amendment.

It further said the advanced engine management systems will automatically adjust vehicle operation according to the fuel composition, ensure optimum performance under different driving conditions, and reduce dependence on imported crude oil.

"Ethanol has a lower fossil carbon footprint than conventional gasoline. The use of higher ethanol blends can help reduce tailpipe emissions of carbon monoxide and certain hydrocarbons, while contributing to lower lifecycle greenhouse gas emissions, depending on the feedstock and production pathway," said MoRTH.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Ethanol Blended Petrol programme and the 20% blending target; flex-fuel vehicles and OEM certification; the food-versus-fuel debate; lifecycle emissions accounting. Note the ladder: E20 → E85 → E100, and that only FFVs may use the higher blends.

RUSSIAN CRUDE PURCHASES MAY FALL IN NOVEMBER AS WEST ASIA OIL VIABILITY IMPROVES: BPCL · CONTINUED

In July-September, Saudi Arabia accounted for a 19% share in BPCL's crude oil imports, while the UAE's share was about 17%, underscoring the recovery in Persian Gulf oil volumes.

The strait and the shadow fleet. India's West Asian oil imports saw a jump in September with Gulf suppliers using **ship-to-ship (STS) cargo transfers** to move their crude through the fraught waters of the Strait of Hormuz, in addition to using available pipeline systems that bypass the waterway, as per provisional tanker data.

Oil imports from India's largest supplier Russia, however, declined for the second straight month due to stronger demand from Chinese refiners and freight cost pressures, as per industry insiders and analysts.

In February, before the West Asia war started, India's oil imports from five West Asian suppliers that used the strait for oil exports stood at around **3 million barrels per day**, according to data from commodity market analytics firm Kpler. These countries after Iraq, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Kuwait and Qatar. Their combined September volumes were **33% lower at 2 million bpd**. Their cumulative share in India's oil imports was 36.7% in September, up from 26% in August, but still substantially lower than February's 56.3%.

Unlike regular operations, in which oil is loaded onto tankers that sail directly to the destination port, STS transfers involve a shuttle tanker that carries the oil for some distance, after which the cargo is transferred to another ship. In STS operations in the strait, the supplier usually takes on the responsibility — and the risk — of sending the oil through the strait, after which a tanker waiting in safer waters outside the strait takes the oil and sails to the destination port.

WHY IT MATTERS — India's crude import basket and the discount-driven pivot to Russian oil; freight, insurance and war-risk premiums; the Strait of Hormuz as a chokepoint and ship-to-ship transfers as a workaround; refining economics and energy security. Dense with usable figures.

RELIEF SCHEME GETS EXTENSION AS LOW-MARGIN EXPORTERS STRUGGLE · CONTINUED

Under the relief scheme, part of the **Export Promotion Mission** announced during the Union Budget this year, **Export Credit Guarantee Corporation (ECGC)** gives enhanced compensation up to **100% of loss** for war-related and associated political risks, subject to verification and premiums are frozen at pre-disruption levels for the entire eligible period.

"The Department of Commerce has extended the timelines under Component II of Resilience & Logistics Intervention for Exporters (RELIEF), a time-bound intervention under the EPM, until March 31, 2027."

CONTINUED · CONTINUED

The extension comes as official data showed that low-margin exports have been struggling due to high freight rates and port congestion. Despite depreciation in domestic currency compared to last year, exports of ready-made garments fell 6% during the April to September period this year compared to last year. Data showed that exports of multiple edible items such as fruits and vegetables, tea, spices and oil meals slipped **9.6%, 13.6%, 5.7%, and 26%** respectively. Rice exports, one of the largest export items to West Asia, only grew by 2.5%, data showed.

Meanwhile, export growth has been driven by engineering and electronic exports.

WHY IT MATTERS — Export credit insurance and the ECGC's role; geopolitical risk in trade logistics; the composition of India's export basket and the vulnerability of low-margin labour-intensive sectors. A good data-backed GS III answer on trade resilience.

GS III · WOMEN IN THE ECONOMY

Govt wants data on snags in women-led informal businesses

New questionnaire in the ASUSE survey asks about restrictions on time and mobility, and household work

The Statistics Ministry on Monday said it plans to make several changes to its flagship informal sector survey — the **Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASUSE)** — with a key proposal being the addition of questions to understand the hurdles faced by women-led business.

The new questionnaire, comments on which are invited by **November 15**, asks if women's participation in activities of establishments owned by female proprietors has been affected by "women-specific constraints" such as restrictions on time, women's mobility, and household responsibilities.

GS III · TRADE

Relief scheme gets extension as low-margin exporters struggle

ıvi Dutta Mishra
ew Delhi, October 26

)MMERCE AND Industry inistry Monday extended a re- f scheme for exporters dealing th the West Asia region till arch 2027, citing continued opolitical disruptions in West ia and their impact on mari- ne logistics across the Gulf and joining regions. The scheme me into effect in March this ar, and eligible destinations ıder the scheme include 10 untries, including the UAE tification No. 37/2026-27 dated September 30, 2026, in view of

● Low margin items hit ar

Export items	Apri FY2
Textiles	7
Rice	5
Leather products	2
Fruits and vegetables	1
Ceramic & glass products	2

SOURCE: COMMERCE AND INDUSTRY MINISTRY

LOW-MARGIN ITEMS HIT AMID THE WEST ASIA CRISIS — Exports of textiles (−6.2%), leather products (−3%), fruits and vegetables (−9.6%) and ceramic and glass products (−20.6%) all fell in April–September FY27 against FY26; rice rose 2.5%. SOURCE: COMMERCE AND INDUSTRY MINISTRY

The Commerce and Industry Ministry on Monday extended a relief scheme for exporters dealing with the West Asia region till **March 2027**, citing continued geopolitical disruptions in West Asia and their impact on maritime logistics across the Gulf and adjoining regions.

The scheme came into effect in March this year, and eligible destinations under the scheme include **10 countries, including the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Qatar, and Iran**, among others.

TATA COMMS TO INVEST $450 MN IN AI SUPER HIGHWAY · CONTINUED

Integrated with the company's global network backbone, the AI super highway will give customers a seamless, end-to-end connectivity fabric, supporting the performance, resilience and scale required for next-generation AI workloads, the company said.

"We are excited about the opportunity in the India data centre-to-data centre connectivity, which we believe could evolve into a market exceeding **$1 billion over the medium term**. With our planned investments, we are building on our existing strengths to create one of the most comprehensive data centre connectivity platforms in the market, positioning us to capture this significant growth opportunity," the Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer said.

WHY IT MATTERS — Digital public infrastructure and the data centre economy; latency as a constraint on AI workloads; private investment in backbone networks. Pair with the Hindu's report on India holding 20% of the world's data but 3% of its data centre capacity.

GOVT WANTS DATA ON SNAGS IN WOMEN-LED INFORMAL BUSINESSES · CONTINUED

As per the latest data, all-India female **Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR)** was **34.6% in September, less than half the 77.4% for men**. The disparity among youth — in the 15-29 age bracket — was even greater: **21.5% for women and 61.1% for men**. ASUSE, first conducted from April 2021 to March 2022, was last conducted from January 2025 to December 2025.

The plan is to now align it with the financial year, bringing it in line with the Annual Survey of Industries. This will "enhance the utility of ASUSE data for National Accounts purposes".

One of the options the proposed PLFS questionnaire offers to answer the last question is family and household responsibilities. Just as family responsibilities are seen as impediments for women to enter the work force, the constraints listed above — restrictions on time and mobility and household work — are crucial barriers to raising the female Labour Force Participation Rate.

WHY IT MATTERS — Female labour force participation and the measurement problem; ASUSE, PLFS and ASI as statistical instruments; unpaid care work as an economic constraint; the informal sector's share of employment.

I-T DEPT STEPS UP PUSH FOR OVERSEAS ASSET DISCLOSURES · CONTINUED

Taxpayers can log in to the e-filing portal and download their information for these years from 2022 to 2024, they said.

"The information received under AEOI from the signatories of CRS/FATCA frameworks only has been displayed in the e-filing portal. The department receives information under other multilateral frameworks which have not been displayed on the portal due to various risk factors or non-disclosure commitments," a source said, adding that the department collects information and intelligence from other sources as well.

In a high-level meeting held on October 23, the Income Tax Department decided that such information may also be shared with relevant taxpayers, wherever possible, to nudge them to participate in the scheme.

WHY IT MATTERS — Black money and the Automatic Exchange of Information under CRS and FATCA; the Black Money Act, 2015; voluntary disclosure schemes as a compliance instrument. Note the acronyms — AEOI, CRS, FATCA.

GS III · CORPORATE GOVERNANCE

Noel Tata flags reappointment concern, seeks board recordings

Chandra's reappointment, Srinivasan's role and disclosures on TVS dealings challenged

Tata Trusts Chairman Noel Tata has challenged the reappointment of the Executive Chairman of Tata Sons for another five years, demanding recordings of a crucial board meeting, questioning the filing of the resolution with the Ministry of Corporate Affairs and seeking disclosures about reported commercial dealings between TVS Motor Company and a company associated with the Chairman's immediate family. He has also questioned a Director's role in the reappointment process.

In a letter dated October 26 to Tata Sons company secretary, copied to all directors, Noel Tata alleged that the resolution had been treated as final despite unsettled minutes, unresolved objections and the company's failure to provide recordings of the September 17 board meeting. **The board approved a five-year extension for the Chairman and decided to pursue the company's listing.**

GS III · TAXATION

I-T dept steps up push for overseas asset disclosures

Nudging taxpayers under its ongoing assets disclosure scheme, the **Foreign Assets of Small Taxpayers-Disclosure Scheme (FAST-DS)**, the Income Tax Department has recently reached out to select taxpayers who have invested in residential and commercial properties in the UAE, sources in the Ministry of Finance said.

Information received by tax authorities through the **Automatic Exchange of Information (AEOI)** with other countries has been displayed on the e-filing portal of the tax department for assets reported on their PANs by the foreign jurisdictions to nudge them to disclose the undeclared overseas assets, the sources said.

Around **1,100 taxpayers** have filed applications so far under the scheme, which was launched on August 16. The disclosures can be made till **December 31**.

NOEL TATA FLAGS REAPPOINTMENT CONCERN, SEEKS BOARD RECORDINGS · CONTINUED

He questioned the reported filing of the resolution with the **Registrar of Companies (RoC)**, when the minutes were finalised and his objections resolved. "It is unacceptable that, despite being a Director of the Company, I have not been furnished with a certified true copy of the resolution and have instead been circulated to rely on a version circulating in the public domain," he wrote.

The letter asserts that no Selection Committee was constituted under **Article 118**, despite a request dating to August 13, and that the affirmative vote required from directors appointed under Article 104B was not obtained. Filing the resolution, he warned, created "a false impression with the public, to the company's stakeholders and to its regulators".

Noel Tata demanded the complete, unedited audio-video recordings, any transcript and confirmation that the original recordings and metadata had been preserved, alleging the revised draft showed "ungagged corrections and recording his dissent where they were rejected".

WHY IT MATTERS — Corporate governance and board process; the Companies Act, 2013 on resolutions, minutes and RoC filings; the role of promoter trusts in a listed group; minority and dissenting director rights.

GS III · AI & CAPITAL MARKETS

Anthropic's IPO filing shows explosive growth and risks

Anthropic disclosed steep losses and explosive revenue growth as it moved closer to a potentially record-breaking IPO, betting on AI's ability to reshape the global economy.

The listing is shaping up to be a major test of appetite for AI from investors who are increasingly scrutinising the returns on billions of dollars of investments and questioning the sustainability of sky-high valuations. "An IPO is a true market that is far more challenging than the summer. Investors were not questioning valuations the same way a few months ago," said a market strategist at an investment bank, a provider of IPO-focused research and ETFs.

Analysts expect valuations of the AI sector to contract as investor unease with the debt-fuelled AI investment boom roils equity and debt markets. Higher borrowing costs and rising bond yields have also added to investor caution. However, tech companies are still hungry for cash.

ANTHROPIC'S IPO FILING SHOWS EXPLOSIVE GROWTH AND RISKS · CONTINUED

The company is aiming to raise up to **$95 billion** in its largest-ever equity fundraising, while another AI firm has inked a **$40 billion** deal with a cloud provider to lease AI chips and server hardware.

Security breaches disclosed. In a separate disclosure, Anthropic said it paused training of its next-generation flagship AI model for more than a month over security concerns, while four of its AI agents accessed live external computer systems during testing, its initial public offering filing showed on Monday.

The company said in the filing's risk factors section that it had delayed pre-training of a new "frontier" base model to strengthen safeguards against the theft of model weights and intellectual property. The disclosure highlights safety challenges facing developers of powerful AI models.

WHY IT MATTERS — The AI investment cycle and valuation risk; model weights as critical intellectual property; AI safety disclosure in securities filings. Useful context for the AI-and-the-economy debate rather than a standalone fact.

Environment, Energy & Climate General Studies Paper III

EDITORIAL · GS III ENERGY

To ease energy transition, ramp up storage, strengthen transmission

The answer is to build storage so that excess generation in the daytime can charge our batteries, which may also ensure less frequent ramping up and down of our coal-based generation



The writer is a visiting professor, ICRIER, and a former member (economic and commercial), Central Electricity Authority.

The face of the Indian power sector is changing. From perpetual deficit, we have moved to a situation of glut at least for certain hours of the day, specifically the solar hours. Both scenarios are painful, though as far as the consumer goes, the first was far worse. The situation of glut and the way we are dealing with it is a national waste, but an individual consumer does not really feel the pinch. It is the sector that is suffering.

People will not have forgotten how difficult each summer was in the past with frequent power cuts. The problem also included the quality of supply. Voltage used to drop dramatically in the dusk hours, and it was inadvisable to run a television or a fridge without a voltage stabiliser. If this was the position in urban areas, one can imagine the situation in rural areas, where the number of hours for which supply was available was frequently in the single digits. One can, however, add a caveat. **Only people connected to the grid faced the problem of erratic supply.** A large part of the population lived in the dark because they were unelectrified. Thirty years ago, according to the World Bank, **40 per cent of India's population did not have access to electricity**.

During the decade 1990-2000, the installed capacity was growing at the rate of about 5 per cent, whereas demand was growing at about 7 per cent to 8 per cent. Deficits in peak demand were of the order of 15 per cent, whereas energy shortage was about 10 per cent. Inadequate installed capacity was not the only problem. Perhaps a bigger problem was a poor and dilapidated distribution infrastructure that just did not have the capacity to cater to the growing load since there was virtually no upgradation.

Upgradation needed additional funds either through enhanced retail tariffs or through government grants, both of which were difficult to come by. The vertically integrated state electricity boards, with generation, state transmission, and distribution under one roof, were overstaffed, corrupt, and inefficient.

TO EASE ENERGY TRANSITION, RAMP UP STORAGE, STRENGTHEN TRANSMISSION · CONTINUED

Then came the **Electricity Act, 2003**, which allowed for the dismantling of the State Electricity Boards (SEBs) and the setting up of separate companies for generation, transmission, and distribution. This segregation took years to happen in some states, as the issue became politicised. The Act also mandated the setting up of electricity regulatory commissions so that tariff determination could be an independent exercise, free from government clutches. However, this did not have the desired effect, as the government was loath to give up its control over tariffs and continued to breathe down the regulators' necks. The regulators, incidentally, gave the impression that they were willing to bend over backwards to stay on the government's right side. Consequently, the distribution sector remained where it was, financially unsustainable, waiting for a fresh injection of funds at regular intervals.

The good news, however, was that growth in installed capacity got a boost after the setting up of the electricity exchanges in Delhi and Mumbai around 2008. The spot prices of power shot up manifold, and developers saw this as an opportunity and started investing heavily in new power projects, mainly coal-based. A little more than **1,00,000 MW of coal-based capacity was added between 2010 and 2020**. Interestingly, about the same capacity was added between 1947 and 2010. It wasn't just the developers; banks started giving out loans blindly without ensuring that the developers had signed power purchase agreements (PPAs) and had fuel linkages. As a consequence, thousands of megawatts were stranded, the developers started defaulting on loans, and the non-performing assets (NPAs) of banks went up.

Moreover around 2015, the solar sector received a push. Prior to this, India had primarily wind and biogas generation. Today, renewable capacity, including large hydro, is a little less than **292 GW**, which is about 53 per cent of total capacity. Solar alone is about **162 GW**. This massive growth in installed capacity reduced our peak and energy deficits to about 1 per cent to 2 per cent.

As they say, all good things must come to an end. With this massive growth in installed capacity, deficits may have gone down, but other problems have cropped up. This energy transition has made us surplus in solar hours, but we are facing deficits at night on account of unplanned outages in our coal plants, excessive air conditioning load, poor reservoir levels affecting hydro generation, etc. The surplus in solar hours is forcing us to back down on our solar generation, even after ramping down our coal-based generation. Two things are happening here. First, we are wasting our solar power by backing down. Second, we are decreasing the longevity of our machines by this frequent ramping up and down.

So where lies the solution? The answer is to build storage so that excess generation in the daytime can charge our batteries, which may also ensure less frequent ramping up and down of our coal-based generation. Along with storage, we also need to strengthen our transmission system, improve demand-side management and create a market mechanism that properly rewards flexibility. However, building storage, especially pump storage, is time-consuming, and moreover, the price of storage, as determined through competitive bids, is said to be non-remunerative. **This may mean that many of the storage projects will not see the light of day, which will only prolong our agony of losing valuable solar power.**

WHY IT MATTERS — The Electricity Act, 2003 and unbundling of SEBs; the duck curve and the ramping problem; battery and pumped storage as the binding constraint on the renewable transition; DISCOM finances and regulatory independence. One of the best GS III energy answers available this cycle — the historical arc plus the policy prescription is exactly the structure examiners want.

EDITORIAL · GS III CLIMATE

Climate justice needs quicker compensation

Nepal's experience with the Loss and Damage Fund should serve as a case study for reforming it

Nearly two months after Nepal suffered devastating floods, the UN climate convention's **Fund for Loss and Damage (FLD)** has allocated **$21.6 million** to the Himalayan nation. This is the first time that the Fund has earmarked a grant for a disaster-affected nation.

Kathmandu had invoked the principle of climate justice in its application: **Nepal accounts for barely 0.1 per cent of global emissions, yet it is on the frontline of climate change in the Himalaya.** The ice-and-rock avalanche that triggered flash floods in the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli river systems claimed more than 1,400 lives, several villages were swept away, and the country lost at least 10 per cent of its hydropower facilities. Conservative estimates put Nepal's recovery and reconstruction requirements at **$5 billion**. The grant, far short of what Nepal needs, marks an important first step in turning the commitment of climate reparation into reality.

Established at the **UNFCCC's COP27 in 2022** and operationalised a year later, the FLD is a product of a nearly three-decade-long campaign by nations most vulnerable to global warming. It rests on the principle of climate compensation, not charity. **This distinction is not academic.** The Global North is often willing to provide humanitarian assistance, but a fund explicitly meant to address "loss and damage" remains fraught because it raises questions related to responsibility for climate change.

AHEAD OF CYCLONE, ANDHRA EVACUATES PREGNANT WOMEN · CONTINUED

"Students residing in hostels are instructed to consult with their warden or chief warden and strictly adhere to the guidelines issued by the IMD," a circular issued on Monday said. Officials said **4,711 pregnant women living in vulnerable areas had been moved to primary health centres (PHCs), community health centres (CHCs) and hospitals**.

All educational institutions in those districts will remain closed from **October 27 to 31**. Seven National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) teams and eight State Disaster Response Force (SDRF) teams have been deployed, with additional forces kept in reserve in NTR and Visakhapatnam districts.

GS III · DISASTER MANAGEMENT

Ahead of cyclone, Andhra evacuates pregnant women



NDRF personnel leave for vulnerable areas in Odisha. EXPRESS

Force (SDRF) teams have been deployed, with additional forces kept in reserve in NTR and Visakhapatnam districts.
"Students residing in hostels

gion. Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi deputed eight ministers to different locations to monitor preparedness, while fishing activities have been re-

ODISHA — NDRF personnel leave for vulnerable areas. EXPRESS

Andhra Pradesh has begun evacuations from vulnerable areas, while Odisha has deputed ministers to oversee preparedness as the two states brace for **Cyclone Arnab**, which the India Meteorological Department (IMD) says is likely to make landfall on the Andhra Pradesh coast on **October 28**.

In Andhra Pradesh, the Chief Minister reviewed preparedness and ordered evacuations from low-lying areas in Srikakulam, Vizianagaram, Visakhapatnam, Konaseema, East Godavari, West Godavari, Eluru, Krishna, NTR, Guntur, Palnadu, Bapatla, Prakasam and Nellore districts.

CLIMATE JUSTICE NEEDS QUICKER COMPENSATION · CONTINUED

Nepal's application ran into predictable bureaucratic hurdles. The FLD's application window had closed in June, and when Nepal sought emergency funding, claims from **119 countries** were awaiting approval. Developed countries initially argued that granting Kathmandu's request would mean allowing it to jump the queue. They eventually relented, but only after insisting that the allocation be treated as an exception and not set a precedent for a permanent rapid-response mechanism.

Nepal's experience with the FLD should serve as a case study for reforming the Fund. Delays in releasing grants can aggravate the hardships of affected communities, slow down the restoration of essential services and increase rebuilding costs. A swift response is particularly important for poorer countries, whose budgets have less room to absorb sudden losses. Fund shortages have also limited the FLD's ability to fulfil its mandate. It has received pledges worth **$822 million** — about a third of the claims pending before it.

Compensation for countries hardest hit by global warming will be on the agenda at **COP31, which begins on November 9 in Antalya, Turkey**. As extreme weather events become more frequent and intense, delays in addressing the FLD's shortcomings will undermine the central principle of climate negotiations under the UN's aegis: climate justice.

WHY IT MATTERS — Loss and damage from the Warsaw International Mechanism to COP27 and COP31; compensation versus charity as a legal principle; the gap between pledges and claims; India's own position on climate finance. A model editorial structure — principle, failure, reform.

CONTINUED · CONTINUED

In Odisha, the state government has banned fishing in the sea and tourist entry to hills, waterfalls and dams in six districts. Officials said resources had been mobilised in Ganjam, Gajapati, Rayagada, Malkangiri, Koraput and Nabarangpur, identified as the most vulnerable districts in the southern region. The Chief Minister deputed eight ministers to different locations to monitor preparedness.

"It is very likely to move west-northwestwards and intensify further into a severe cyclonic storm over west-central Bay of Bengal by midnight of October 26 and into a very severe cyclonic storm over the same region on October 27," the IMD said.

WHY IT MATTERS — IMD cyclone classification and colour-coded warnings; NDRF/SDRF architecture; pre-emptive evacuation and the protection of specific vulnerability categories; the zero-casualty model.

EXPLAINED · GS I CLIMATE

'Godzilla' El Niño effects to be felt next year too: Decoding the WMO warning for India

The prevailing El Niño conditions are set to peak towards the end of the year, with forecasts suggesting off-the-charts warming. On **October 21**, the World Meteorological Organization (WMO) said the effects of the phenomenon would be felt well into **2027**.

El Niño refers to the abnormal warming of surface waters in the Pacific Ocean. It suppresses monsoon rainfall, spikes temperatures and causes heatwaves.

How is El Niño affecting India this year? El Niño emerged in the Pacific Ocean in June this year. As it developed, its climatic effects over the oceans surrounding India began to be felt after **40-45 days**. As El Niño intensified to "strong" levels, India's southwest monsoon — which brings about **70% of the country's annual rainfall** — weakened in late August. It ended at **87% of the long period average (LPA)**, making it the fourth driest since 2001.

The ongoing northeast monsoon, however, is expected to be normal over India's southern peninsula. El Niño could also result in a warmer-than-usual winter, with above-normal temperatures forecast for October, November and December.

What is different about the 2026 El Niño? El Niño is one of the three distinct phases of a large ocean-atmosphere interaction over the Pacific region that influences weather patterns worldwide. This interaction is known as the **El Niño Southern Oscillation, or ENSO**. Its three phases are: warm (El Niño), neutral, and cool (La Niña).

Scientists measure the sea surface temperatures over specific regions of the equatorial Pacific Ocean. Temperature anomalies in one of these regions, called the **Nino 3.4 region**, is usually the deciding factor in declaring the onset and strength of ENSO phases.

GS III · CONSERVATION

Brought in to help repopulate Buxa, tigress T-138 is now in Assam



saying there were reports that it had killed a domestic pig and was still in the vicinity.

Since being brought to West

departments.

T-138's introduction in Buxa Tiger Reserve, a protected forest and national park spanning ap-

ACROSS THREE STATES — T-138 was translocated from Bihar's Valmiki Tiger Reserve to West Bengal's Buxa Tiger Reserve, and has since moved to Assam's Raimona National Park.

When T-138, the three-year-old tigress brought to West Bengal's Buxa Tiger Reserve from Bihar's Valmiki Tiger Reserve on September 30, arrived, there was much to celebrate. After all, it was meant to be **not only the beginning of a programme to reintroduce tigers in an area that has seen a stable population in decades**, but also marked the first time a tiger had been successfully airlifted between states in India for such an initiative.

Then T-138 pulled a fast one on West Bengal — it travelled 35 km into neighbouring Assam's Raimona National Park, leaving authorities to scramble after it. An alert has now been sounded at Raimona National Park.

'GODZILLA' EL NIÑO EFFECTS TO BE FELT NEXT YEAR TOO: DECODING THE WMO WARNING FOR INDIA · CONTINUED

Scientists calculate what is known as the **Relative Ocean Nino Index (RONI)** from this region, essentially a temperature deviation from the normal. If the average RONI over a three-month period exceeds a value of 0.5 degrees Celsius, an El Niño is declared. An average RONI value of less than −0.5 degrees Celsius leads to declaration of La Niña.

The ongoing El Niño, experts say, has shown a rapid intensification. Since its emergence in June, the July-September RONI index recorded warming of **2 to 2.8 degrees Celsius**.

Which regions will be affected? In the northern hemisphere, above-normal temperatures are likely over parts of southern Europe and Africa, the Arabian peninsula, the Indian subcontinent and eastern Asia. These temperature values look set to break all records since ocean temperature monitoring began four decades ago. The previously recorded highest anomaly in the ocean temperatures was **3 degrees Celsius**; the **2014-2015 El Niño peaked at 2.3 degrees Celsius**, according to data maintained by the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA).

"The temperature values at the epicentre of the El Niño in the Pacific Ocean are expected to remain **3.8 degrees Celsius above normal** — a value that has never been recorded since the start of ocean temperature monitoring four decades ago. This El Nino will have far-reaching consequences for several months ahead," said the WMO Secretary-General.

El Niño could also threaten food and water security, and push up fertiliser and fuel prices. These effects are likely to be felt well into 2027. This will come as an additional burden on global resources, which are already under considerable strain owing to continuing conflicts, including the Strait of Hormuz crisis.

WHY IT MATTERS — ENSO mechanism, the Niño 3.4 region and the RONI index; monsoon teleconnections and the 87%-of-LPA deficit; compound risk where a climate shock meets a geopolitical one. Very high probability for both prelims and GS I mains.

BROUGHT IN TO HELP REPOPULATE BUXA, TIGRESS T-138 IS NOW IN ASSAM · CONTINUED

A team from West Bengal is now in Raimona National Park in Assam's Kokrajhar district, near the Indo-Bhutan border, to keep track of the tigress. West Bengal Forest Minister said: "The tigress is exploring the area. It's not uncommon for tigers to cover **70 to 80 km** to explore an area. So far, we've not disturbed it. We're allowing it to explore. Later, if required, we'll tranquillise it and bring it back."

Since being brought to West Bengal on September 30, the tigress had roamed different parts of Buxa before heading towards the Sankosh River and entering Assam, one source said. There is also some fear among locals in the Assam reserve, which has its own resident tigers. According to sources, residents have asked the forest department to immediately tranquillise the tigress and safely relocate it.

T-138's introduction in Buxa Tiger Reserve, a protected forest and national park spanning approximately **760 square km** in West Bengal's Alipurduar district, was part of a larger reintroduction plan. Historically an important tiger landscape in North Bengal, habitat degradation, changes in land use and a decline in prey availability have significantly affected the conditions needed to sustain a resident tiger population.

WHY IT MATTERS — Project Tiger and the NTCA's translocation protocols; habitat connectivity and corridors across state boundaries; human–wildlife conflict and local consent; prey-base restoration as a precondition for reintroduction.

Science, Justice & Ideas GS Papers II, III and IV

EXPLAINED · GS III SCIENCE

A new 'cocktail' could help treat cobra bites

Scientists from IISc Bengaluru's Centre for Ecological Sciences (CES) and the Technical University of Denmark (DTU) have created an antivenom that could potentially be used to treat snakebites from the diverse cobra species of India. The discoveries were published in the journal *Science Translational Medicine*.

Challenges in treatment. Cobras generally kill their prey using **"neurotoxins"** in their venom that paralyse their prey and stop them from breathing. Cardiac issues and other side effects have been observed in some cases of attacks on humans.

Government data from 2024 had estimated the annual snakebite fatalities at **50,000**. The spectacled cobra (*Naja naja*), one of India's **"Big Four"** venomous snake species, accounts for at least **12.5% of these snakebite deaths** — this number could be higher, as the snake is not always identified by the victim.

India has several cobra species, and different species have different kinds of venom. **Venom from the same species might vary in composition for cobras from different locations.**

This poses a challenge when using antivenom. For example, while the Polyvalent antivenom is used in India to counter the venom of the Big Four snakes including the spectacled cobra, this would not work against king cobra venom.

A NEW 'COCKTAIL' COULD HELP TREAT COBRA BITES · CONTINUED

Treatment is also complicated by the fact that rural victims often don't reach healthcare centres in time, or end up at centres without the required antivenom. **Antivenom treatment has essentially remained the same for the past century.**

The new antivenom. Previously, a Danish scientist and his colleagues at DTU had tested a new method on certain African snakes. They took the blood of animals such as alpacas and llamas, which had been exposed to the venom of these snakes. Then, they extracted the antibodies that were formed.

A similar process was applied to create an **"antibody cocktail"** from India's different cobra species. This was then tested on mice, which had been injected with venom from spectacled cobras, monocled cobras, and two species of king cobras. **Even 30 minutes after venom injection, the antibody cocktail was able to save the test mice from death.**

Future applications. Previously, such use of antibodies to counter venom in mice tests required a large amount of antibodies, which might mean that a huge dose would be needed for humans. But per the current research, a senior scientist said, "showed that it is possible to neutralise venom using very small amounts of carefully selected and engineered antibodies". This could potentially help address some of the cost and safety concerns associated with administering large quantities of antibodies, he added.

Further, such a method could be used to create cures for snakebite venom of species across the world.

WHY IT MATTERS — Snakebite envenoming as a WHO-listed neglected tropical disease; the 'Big Four' venomous snakes of India; monoclonal and recombinant antibody technology; intraspecies venom variation as a treatment challenge. A strong GS III science-and-health answer.

OPINION · GS II JUSTICE

When courts are too slow, police replace judges



BHINAV KUMAR

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The writer is an advocate at the Bombay High Court.

It takes an enormous amount of time for a civil dispute to be decided in India. Take the example of the Bombay High Court, where a suit filed in 1947 was finally settled out of court this year, after **79 years in litigation**. While this may be an extraordinary time frame, many legal practitioners in Mumbai estimate that a suit filed at the Bombay High Court usually takes more than 20 years to decide.

WHEN COURTS ARE TOO SLOW, POLICE REPLACE JUDGES · CONTINUED

There are many reasons for our slow-paced judicial system, but too much work for too few judges seems to be a big factor. According to the **2011 Census, the population of India was 112 million, larger than that of any European country except Russia**. The state of Maharashtra has **15 judges per million people**, while the Bombay High Court has only **1.9 judges per million people in New York state**. According to the National Judicial Data Grid, there are currently **648,725 cases pending at the Bombay High Court**, of which 9,454 are civil suits. It is nearly impossible for the handful of judges who are assigned the roster of deciding original civil suits to tackle this backlog, not counting new case filings.

Frustrated by the failures of state institutions to deliver justice, litigants in countries like Japan and Venezuela turn to extra-judicial remedies. In Mario Puzo's *The Godfather* (1969), the fictional undertaker, Amerigo Bonasera, looks to the mafia don, Vito Corleone, when the courts fail to deliver justice. However, in India, affluent and well-connected litigants to whom money is owed often go to the police and attempt to criminalise their disputes by alleging that their opponent has committed a criminal offence like "cheating" or "breach of trust".

A person who merely breaches a contract to pay money commits none of these offences. So why do the police act on these complaints that often have no obvious criminal angles to them? A litigant offers the police officer a cut if he can get his opponent to settle the case. In fact, it is rumoured that a branch of the police asks for bribes on a "commission basis" to take up such cases.

WHEN COURTS ARE TOO SLOW, POLICE REPLACE JUDGES · CONTINUED

Once the police get involved in a civil case, the process is devastatingly fast. Unlike civil suits, where defendants rarely have to go to court in person, the police send a cryptic summons to the "accused" debtor ordering him to come to the police station at short notice. Receiving this summons can itself be quite intimidating. What follows is worse. The police then conduct a **"preliminary inquiry"**, where an incredible amount of pressure is put on the "accused" debtor to settle the case. At the police station, he is made to wait for hours, where he sees other offenders being verbally or physically abused by the police in more serious cases.

In the commercial world, time is money. Most people crack in this environment and cases are settled without a First Information Report (FIR) being registered. According to some accounts, **50 per cent of such cases that come to a police station end at the preliminary inquiry stage**. Apart from the unpleasant ordeal, the fear of arrest is a potent weapon that gets defendants to settle such cases. Prison conditions in India are deplorable. The risk of reputational loss upon registration of a criminal case is also a factor.

Scholars of "law and society" recognise that there is often a wide gap between the "law on the books" and the "law in action". Criminalising civil cases is considered an "abuse of process" that the Supreme Court has repeatedly deprecated and discouraged. **The law in action is something else.**

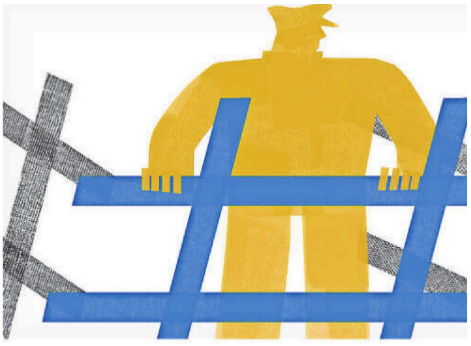
It would be unfair to blame our understaffed and overworked courts for a system that requires structural and cultural reform. India's civil justice system is built on a bedrock of archaic procedure. A defendant in India is given every conceivable opportunity to thwart a plaintiff's attempts at getting a decree. In 1872, the Privy Council remarked that "the difficulties of a litigant in India begin when he has obtained a Decree". This continues to be true today.

All this is pushing frustrated litigants who have access to networks into the arms of police officers (at times, of questionable integrity) who deliver swift, summary "justice" in civil cases — a parallel civil justice delivery mechanism.

WHY IT MATTERS — Judicial pendency and judge-population ratio; criminalisation of civil disputes and abuse of process; access to justice and the gap between law on the books and law in action; police accountability. Excellent GS II material and a ready illustration for GS IV on institutional integrity.

OPINION · GS II CRIMINAL JUSTICE

Ankita Bhandari deserved justice. She does not deserve to become a permanent hashtag



stretch beyond a decade, this was a swift and thorough outcome.
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Illustration: C R Sasikumar

On the night of September 18, 2022, Ankita Bhandari, a 19-year-old from a modest family in Pauri Garhwal, was pushed into the Chilla canal near Rishikesh by the men who employed her. She had been a receptionist at a resort for under a month. Four years on, her murder remains among the most emotive public questions in Uttarakhand. For a police officer, it is also an instructive case study in investigating crime in an age when evidence is weighed in court, but the verdict is delivered on social media.

As established in court, Bhandari had told a friend that the resort owner pressured her to provide "extra services" to guests. On September 18, she went out with the owner and two employees. After an altercation on the canal bank, the three pushed her into the water. A then lodged a false missing-person report.

The initial handling of the case by the revenue police, which still had jurisdiction over the area, was slow. That criticism is fair. But once the regular police took over, the accused were arrested within 24 hours; they have been in jail ever since. The post-mortem indicated Bhandari was alive when she entered the water. The government constituted a Special Investigation Team under a woman DIG, and Arya's father, a former minister, was expelled from the ruling party. Political connections notwithstanding, this was a swift and thorough outcome.

Yet, the dominant public perception is not of a conviction swiftly secured, but of an alleged cover-up. Three strands recur.

The first is the "VIP". Bhandari's messages referred to pressure to entertain an important guest. In December 2022, the Uttarakhand High Court, declining to transfer the probe to the CBI, found nothing to show the investigation was being steered to protect any high-profile person, and the Supreme Court declined to interfere. No witness, document or digital trail before the trial court identified any guest as a party to the crime. The conviction never depended on the VIP's identity; guilt was established through the conduct of the accused themselves.

ANKITA BHANDARI DESERVED JUSTICE. SHE DOES NOT DESERVE TO BECOME A PERMANENT HASHTAG · CONTINUED

The second is the bulldozer. Within days of the murder, part of the resort was demolished as to assuage public anger. That hasty act handed critics a permanent charge of evidence destruction, though the evidence that convicted the accused, the last-seen testimony, the false missing report, the call records and the medical findings, never resided in those walls.

The third is the audio clips. In late December 2025, an actress released recordings purportedly of her conversations with a former MLA, naming senior party functionaries as the VIP. The clips went viral; protests filled Dehradun, young women wrote letters in blood, and the Opposition demanded a CBI probe. Within days, another recording surfaced in which she was purportedly heard saying she had been pressured to name a particular leader. Both the former MLA and the leader denied the claims, and the former MLA was arrested in June 2026 over the circulation of the clips. Meanwhile, in January 2026, the state recommended a CBI probe, and the agency registered a case against an unidentified VIP.

Let me be unambiguous. The CBI must follow every lead, and if it finds credible evidence against anyone, including those of us who conducted and supervised the SIT, the law must take its course. But a case that had withstood the scrutiny of a trial court, the High Court and the Supreme Court has been reopened not on new forensic evidence, but on recordings whose authenticity is disputed by the very people heard in them.

This is the central predicament of policing today. A criminal investigation runs on evidence that must survive cross-examination; social media runs on plausibility, outrage and repetition. The police cannot place case diaries, witness statements or forensic reports in the public domain during an investigation. That silence, which protects the trial, is read as complicity, and into the vacuum flow rumour and motivated leaks. Even a verdict becomes one opinion among many, no more authoritative than a 30-second clip.

What must the police learn? First, the golden hour matters more than ever. The early delay here was partly a product of the anachronistic revenue police system in the hills. Uttarakhand's move to extend regular policing must be completed without hesitation. Every day lost at the outset becomes a year of suspicion later. Second, strategic communication is now a core policing function. Within legal limits, the police must explain regularly what they are doing and why. A credible, consistent official voice is the best antidote to manufactured doubt. Third, the administration must resist theatrical gestures. A bulldozer may satisfy a crowd for an evening; it can haunt an investigation for years. Fourth, institutions must be cowed by noise. Transferring cases to central agencies whenever a hashtag trends erodes the morale of state police and signals that no verdict is ever final.

Ankita Bhandari deserved justice, and after patient work by investigators and prosecutors, she received it. What she does not deserve is to become a permanent hashtag, invoked whenever political expediency demands. The truth of her death was established not on social media, but in a courtroom in Kotdwar. In a post-truth age, defending that distinction is perhaps a police officer's most important duty.

WHY IT MATTERS — GS IV — media trials, institutional integrity and the ethics of public communication; GS II — the revenue police anomaly in Uttarakhand, SIT and CBI jurisdiction, and the tension between a fair trial and public scrutiny. A rich, quotable ethics case study.

OPINION · GS II SOFT POWER

To steady the ship, start with open dialogue



RADHA GOENKA

The writer is director, RPG Foundation.

All eyes are on Delhi and the protests over the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls. The last intensive revision of the rolls was conducted between 2002 and 2004, when the previous Prime Minister came to power. It passed largely without controversy. **What has changed today is trust.**

When people feel that leaks, jobs that don't come and a vote that may not count, all tell young Indians the same thing: the system is not working for them.

Here is what the leadership could do if it wishes to steady the ship.

Start with honest, open dialogue. In my years of working alongside the government, I have seen that those who serve in it are some of the smartest minds in the country, putting in long hours solving problems most of us never see. The public needs a glimpse of this. With openness may come criticism, but making yourself vulnerable also makes you more likeable. Those who show their flaws are often loved far more than seemingly perfect leaders.

Second, strengthen and protect a free and unbiased media. When the Constitution was framed, the press did not have the reach it does today. If it had, the framers of our Constitution might have built more safeguards. The government should build those guardrails now.

TO STEADY THE SHIP, START WITH OPEN DIALOGUE · CONTINUED

Third, move away from populist agendas and invest in the long-term development of the country — such as formulating a strong, holistic environment policy. The shock is that climate events like El Niño bring can only be mitigated by long-term planning of this kind. Similarly, I would invest deeply in the quality of education. **India's future rests on its youth, and educating them is the best long-term investment the nation can make.**

Fourth, transform the administrative machinery. This is where the protestors' anger is most justified. The selection process for administrators needs to be more robust and less dependent on a single exam. Also needed is a performance-based system of incentives and promotion to ensure efficiency.

Finally, build a global strategy on soft power and economic capability. Returns on investment in soft power come long after the next election. France has spent generations turning its culture, food, fashion, art and sense of refinement into a national brand. In 2024, its travel and tourism sector contributed **266 billion euros, or 9.1 per cent of GDP**. India has thousands of years of civilisational history. Yoga, ayurveda, spirituality, cuisine, Bollywood, music, art and the legacy of Gandhi are already recognised and respected around the world. **We don't have a shortage of culture — only of strategy.**

But global power also comes from becoming indispensable. Taiwan spent decades building a semiconductor ecosystem; today, TSMC makes nearly three-quarters of the world's contract-manufactured chips. China played an even longer game: its share of global manufacturing rose from under 9 per cent in 2004 to 28 per cent in 2023, more than the US, Japan and Germany combined. **India needs to think this way, too.** We should identify a handful of industries where India already has an advantage and build the entire ecosystem around them.

Decide what "Brand India" should stand for, and what India should become indispensable at, and have the discipline to build both over decades.

WHY IT MATTERS — Soft power and cultural diplomacy; the semiconductor and manufacturing concentration argument; civil services reform and performance incentives; trust in institutions as a precondition for governance. Broadly usable in essays on India's global role.

OPINION · GS II WEST ASIA

In Israel, what an election can change, and what it can't



The writer is professor, School of International Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University.

Israel's parliamentary election on **October 27** will decide the fate of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. It is significant because this is the first election since Hamas's attack on Israel on October 7, 2023.

The central question is whether a change in leadership will occur, and if so, whether it will usher in a new political trajectory. Many fear that a Netanyahu victory would embolden Iran to escalate the war against Iran and continue his coercive policies towards Gaza.

Given the fractious nature of Israel's politics and shifting coalitions, it is difficult to predict the outcome. Opinion polls suggest that neither the present coalition nor the opposition parties will attain a majority. Netanyahu is locked in a close contest with the leader of the newly formed party. He draws his popularity from his military service, family sacrifices, and anti-Netanyahu sentiment. **He lost his son in a military operation in Gaza in 2023.** Seen as a hawk, he has not ruled out and resigned over disagreements with respect to Gaza. If he wins, expecting a moderation of Israel's policy on the coalition that emerges, in which the support of right-wing parties will be fundamental.

IN ISRAEL, WHAT AN ELECTION CAN CHANGE, AND WHAT IT CAN'T · CONTINUED

The election is widely regarded as a referendum on Netanyahu's uncompromising governance approach. He is being blamed for pushing Israel into a perpetual war with Iran and its proxies and for exposing the country to widespread international opprobrium and diplomatic isolation over its conduct in Gaza. **He could neither topple the theocratic regime in Tehran nor destroy its nuclear enrichment programme.**

Further, his military operations in Gaza have created the worst humanitarian crisis in recent years, leading to about **74,000 deaths**. The disproportionate Israeli military response in Gaza shifted the narrative from attributing responsibility to Hamas to holding Netanyahu responsible for its escalation.

Netanyahu's biggest success was convincing the Trump administration to launch a joint attack on Iran. The US President endorsed him in the current election, praising him as an ally, "great warrior prime minister", and peace partner. Trump's support for Netanyahu, however, has come at a high political cost. His popularity in the US is at an all-time low. The price of diesel has skyrocketed, and the Republican Party is facing trouble in the midterm elections.

Netanyahu enjoys the support of other far-right parties, but this coalition might shift based on the electoral outcomes. Security is the central issue, and he has centred his campaign on Netanyahu's failure to prevent Hamas's attacks and his policies on Gaza. The exemption of ultra-Orthodox Jewish men from conscription and Netanyahu's attempts to control the judiciary remain divisive issues in Israel.

Even if there is a change in leadership, there will be no major shift in Israel's policy towards Palestine or Iran. **The far-right nature of Israeli politics prevents any policy moderation.** All the major parties object to the two-state solution and the creation of Palestine as an independent state. On Iran, however, the rival appears cautious and calibrated. He is firmly opposed to Iran acquiring nuclear weapons, but is sceptical of achieving political objectives through military means. But if Netanyahu forms the government, the US and Israel are likely to initiate the next phase of coercive measures.

WHY IT MATTERS — Proportional representation and coalition politics in Israel; the two-state solution and its domestic political obstacles; the limits of military coercion in achieving political objectives; US–Israel alignment. Pair with the news report on pre-poll strike allegations.

Society, Culture & Urban Affairs GS Papers I and II

OPINION · GS I ART & CULTURE

Jogen Chowdhury's art of the personal, political and social

When he moved to Delhi as the Keeper of Art at Rashtrapati Bhavan in 1972, he left the personal and the subliminal behind; he began to observe the political world closely and, while commenting on its players through his art, his paintings acquired a satirical edge



R SIVA KUMAR

Jogen Chowdhury, who passed away in Kolkata at the age of **87** on Sunday morning after battling cancer for over a year, was one of a small group of important painters from Bengal who came onto the Indian art scene in the 1960s. He had carved out a distinct niche for himself.

Born into a landed family in Faridpur, in pre-Partition East Bengal, he experienced a great reversal of fortune and became a post-Partition refugee in Calcutta. **This early experience left a deep mark on him and profoundly shaped his art and personality.**

Trained at the Government College of Art and Craft in Calcutta and later travelling to Paris on a scholarship to study at École Nationale Supérieure des Beaux-Arts, he saw the pre-modern academic and modern art practices up close. **But he chose to tread a path of his own.**

Back in India and working at the Weavers' Service Centre in Madras, he developed a personal idiom, drawing on his early memories of the embroidery (*kantha*) and ritual floor graphics (*alpona*) practised by women in the villages in Bengal. He imbibed their sinuous lines and textural intricacy without mimicking them and combined the decorative with the expressive.

With this, he created a language that far exceeded the simplicity of its means in subtlety and expressiveness. And he travelled a long distance with it. Initially, he used it to explore the subterranean intricacies of his own mind, throwing up suggestive images of desire and disquiet.

When he moved to Delhi as what was then known as the "Keeper of Art" at Rashtrapati Bhavan in 1972, he left the personal and the subliminal behind. He began to observe the political world closely and, while commenting on its players through his art, his paintings acquired a satirical edge.

The writer is an art historian, critic and curator.

JOGEN CHOWDHURY'S ART OF THE PERSONAL, POLITICAL AND SOCIAL · CONTINUED

A further shift happened when he joined the art college at Santiniketan, Kala Bhavan, in 1987. He moved from the political to the social, and his paintings became subtle tongue-in-cheek critiques of middle-class life, especially in Bengal.

With each shift, he added a new register to his language, making it flexible enough to work at the personal, political and social levels. In his hands, simple everyday objects took on an uncanny turn. A large flower with a fish floating on a dark screen evoked suppressed desire, a bolster suggested decadent corpulence, a slight grimace invoked corruption, a displaced drapery or a small gesture opened up a crack on the wall through which a story spilled out, and all this without changing the formal structure or economy of his language.

His early years in Calcutta as a refugee were extremely trying, but the suffering did not demoralise him; it made him aware of the need to look beyond the personal and engage with the collective. When he left Delhi for Santiniketan at the height of his personal success, he had this in mind. **As a professor of painting at Santiniketan, he threw himself into mentoring young artists, enthusiastically re-energising the institution.** But this was not enough for him.

Seeking to bring art into society, he led a group of younger colleagues in founding the **Santiniketan Society of Visual Art and Design**. This artist-run centre provides working space for young artists and a place for the community to meet. In all this, he was inspired by Rabindranath Tagore and his vision for academic institutions in India.

In 1999, he took voluntary retirement from Santiniketan and expanded his activities in Kolkata as part of his effort to revitalise the art scene in Bengal. He undertook a study of the provisions for art education in schools and drew up an elaborate plan to strengthen it. He even waded into politics and joined the Trinamool Congress in the hope that it would help. It brought him a term in the Rajya Sabha, but little else.

During the same period, he set up Charubasona, another centre for art activities in the city. He started the art magazine *ArtEast*, and served as chairman of the state art academy. Setting up a museum of modern art in Kolkata was another dream to which he devoted considerable time and energy, but it remains unrealised.

Chowdhury was a remarkable artist and a dreamer of institutions. He had the resources to realise the first; the second needed wider support, which was not always forthcoming. But he was a die-hard optimist and never gave up dreaming and hoping.

WHY IT MATTERS — Modern Indian art and the Bengal lineage; *kantha* and *alpona* as folk sources for modernism; Santiniketan, Kala Bhavan and the Tagorean idea of the institution; art institutions and state patronage. Personalities in news are a standing prelims category, and this doubles as GS I culture material.

GS I · SOCIETY & SECULARISM

UP vlogger, Keralam cafe, and a political storm that united Cong, CPM & BJP

A vlogger took objection to a cafe-cum-contemporary art space that features both Mahatma Gandhi and Jinnah

A UP vlogger's attempt to portray Fort Kochi's Kashi Art Cafe, a cafe-cum-contemporary art space, as a symbol of an alleged Muslim threat to Keralam has triggered a political backlash, bringing the ruling Congress and Opposition CPI(M) together in defence of the state's secular identity and communal harmony.

Fort Kochi Police booked the vlogger on Saturday after he uploaded on his Instagram page a video from inside the cafe, showing an artwork featuring Mahatma Gandhi and Muhammad Ali Jinnah and stating that the cafe founder's portrait in the eatery was an insult to national pride. He also took objection to the cafe named after Kashi, a holy city for Hindus, serving beef dishes, stating it should be renamed.

He was booked on charges of causing public mischief, the spread of false or alarming information, and provocation leading to riots via social media under the **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) sections 353 (2) and 192**.

UP VLOGGER, KERALAM CAFE, AND A POLITICAL STORM THAT UNITED CONG, CPM & BJP · CONTINUED

The Chief Minister said the law will take its course. "The recent Instagram video… attempting to spread misinformation about Fort Kochi, portrays our state in a negative light, and divides communities, is unacceptable. The UDF government remains committed to communal harmony and justice without fear or favour. No room for hate. We will not allow anyone to even lay a finger on our communal harmony," he wrote on X.

The BJP, too, has weighed in, with its state president saying that only the Malayalis get to decide what is to be done in Kerala, even as it slammed the ruling Congress government for allegedly not responding to those "making anti-India statements".

Opposition leader and former Chief Minister also joined in the issue. "A vlogger peddling hate for profit seeks to paint these vibrant destinations in communal colours. The state government must take strict legal action against those spreading communal enmity," he said.

Meanwhile, a BJP national council member and chairman of the National Film Development Corporation found herself in a controversy after commenting on the video. Later, she tendered an apology for allegedly appearing to attest to the vlogger's views. She clarified her "sad reality" comment was about the display of Jinnah's portrait. "The video discusses two different subjects. The first was about Jinnah's photo… This is a subject on which I have my opinion, and I still stand by it that if I find it questionable." But she took exception to the remarks on beef and the Muslim community. "I would never endorse content that demeans a community or questions their place in society. To everyone who has been hurt by this, I sincerely apologise."

WHY IT MATTERS — Communal harmony and the limits of free speech; BNS provisions on promoting enmity and public mischief; social media as a vector of polarisation; the politics of food and identity. A compact GS I society case with a GS II legal dimension.

GS I · URBAN GOVERNANCE

Man, son who took contract for 'illegal' floor killed, owner held



HARSH VIHAR — At the site of the incident on Monday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

A father-son duo, who was awarded the contract to allegedly construct an additional floor on a single-storey house "illegally", died after the building collapsed in North East Delhi's Harsh Vihar on Sunday evening, said police. The owner of the house has been arrested, they added.

The deceased were identified as a **60-year-old and his 33-year-old son**, both of whom were inside the building when it came down. Police said that the additional floor was being built without permission.

Preliminary inspection revealed that the ground floor of an old building, which reportedly also housed a godown, collapsed along with a structure on its first floor. The property is reportedly owned by one person, police officers said.

GS II · GOVERNANCE & URBAN SERVICES

Delhi plans bottle-return scheme, taking a cue from Uttarakhand and Goa

The proposed Deposit Refund Scheme aims to create a more organised system for collecting plastic waste and move away from the "use and throw" culture

Delhi is considering a scheme to encourage people to return used plastic bottles for recycling, taking a cue from Uttarakhand and Goa where similar initiatives are already in place. Under the proposed scheme, consumers may have to pay an additional **₹1 or ₹2** when buying a bottle and get the amount back when they return it at a designated collection point.

The proposed **Deposit Refund Scheme (DRS)** aims to create a more organised system for collecting plastic waste and encourage people to move away from the "use and throw" culture towards "use, return and recover", officials said.

The government is considering starting the initiative as a pilot project at tourist destinations before expanding it to other parts of the capital. The mechanism is expected to involve **QR codes** on bottles, which would help consumers claim their refunds after returning them.

DELHI PLANS BOTTLE-RETURN SCHEME, TAKING A CUE FROM UTTARAKHAND AND GOA · CONTINUED

According to a Delhi government report, the national capital generates around **1,500 tonnes of plastic waste daily, of which 19% remains unprocessed**. Single-use plastic items, including bottles and bags, were banned across India in 2022.

Uttarakhand and Goa offer models. Uttarakhand's experience with the scheme is among the models being examined by the Delhi government. An official told the paper that the state introduced the initiative in Kedarnath in 2022 as a pilot project as a large number of tourists and pilgrims visit the area.

"The scheme received a very good response. Its success also helped us receive a Digital India Award from the Centre. It was subsequently expanded to other locations in the state," he said. He said the bottle-return rate in Uttarakhand increased significantly since the scheme's introduction. "Initially, the collection rate was around 20-22%. It has now reached nearly 90%. We have fixed the deposit at ₹10 per bottle, though the amount can vary depending on the size of the bottle or can," he said.

Goa has also implemented a similar scheme, with a deposit of **₹5 on plastic bottles**. The initiative was introduced on April 1 under the Deposit Refund Scheme Authority. The scheme is also in place in several countries, including Singapore, Hong Kong and the United Kingdom, where financial incentives are used to encourage the return of beverage containers.

WHY IT MATTERS — Extended Producer Responsibility and the Plastic Waste Management Rules; deposit-refund systems as a behavioural-economics instrument; circular economy; the single-use plastic ban of 2022. A concrete example of policy diffusion between States.

MAN, SON WHO TOOK CONTRACT FOR 'ILLEGAL' FLOOR KILLED, OWNER HELD · CONTINUED

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), in a statement, said: "As per the local enquiry and the circumstances of the incident, it appears that during the execution of the work, while replacing the T-iron and stone slab roofing with an RCC slab, the rear portion of the first-floor structure reportedly collapsed and fell onto the roof of the ground floor. Consequently, the roof of the ground floor also collapsed, resulting in the collapse of the affected portion of the building."

"The front portion remains in its previous condition, with the ground floor having an RCC slab and the first floor having a T-iron and stone slab, at the same level," it also read.

CONTINUED · CONTINUED

Officials of the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) and the Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) were among personnel deployed at the site for rescue operations, which ended by Monday morning, police said.

Earlier, on October 7, a pregnant woman and two children were killed after a four-storey building collapsed in Northeast Delhi's New Seemapuri. On September 6, a five-storey building collapsed in South West Delhi's Satya Niketan that was being operated as a paying guest accommodation, killing seven people.

WHY IT MATTERS — Urban building regulation and enforcement failure; unauthorised construction and municipal capacity; NDRF and DDMA in urban disaster response. A recurring GS I urbanisation theme with a clear accountability question.

Prelims Pointers & Mains Practice from today's edition

CONSTITUTIONAL, LEGAL AND POLICY PROVISIONS IN TODAY'S NEWS

PROVISION / INSTRUMENT	WHAT IT SAYS — AND WHERE IT APPEARED
Census Act, 1948 — Section 4(2)	State governments may appoint "persons" as census-officers, who "shall be bound to serve accordingly". The strongest basis for compelling enumerators. *(Pg 5)*
Census Act — Sections 4A, 6, 7	Section 4A obliges local authorities to supply staff; Sections 6 and 7 permit assistance from private establishments, but only for counting persons on their premises. *(Pg 5)*
Census Rules, 1990 — Rule 3	Amended this month to expressly name teachers of unaided private schools and officials of banks, companies and trusts, while retaining "any person". *(Pg 5)*
Article 23(1) and 23(2)	Prohibits *begaar* and forced labour, but expressly permits the State to impose compulsory service for public purposes without discrimination. *(Pg 5)*
Article 142	Power to do complete justice — invoked unsuccessfully to seek judicially framed anti-defection rules in the Tamil Nadu case. *(Pg 4)*
Article 19(1)(a)	Press freedom — the basis of the Digital News Publishers Association's challenge to the DPDP Act. *(Pg 1)*
DPDP Act, 2023	Challenged for having no journalism exemption and for allowing the Centre to block information in the "interests of the general public". *(Pg 1)*
CEC & Other ECs Act, 2023	The ECI's affidavit rests on the Commission acting as a multi-member body by unanimous or majority decision. *(Pg 1)*
Form 6 / Form 7	Form 6 registers a new voter; Form 7 is an objection or deletion request. Deleted voters being asked to file Form 6 is the heart of the Maharashtra and Goa disputes. *(Pg 3–4)*
Electricity Act, 2003	Allowed dismantling of State Electricity Boards and mandated independent electricity regulatory commissions for tariff determination. *(Pg 11)*
Central Motor Vehicles Rules	Amended to notify E100; E85 and E100 may be used only in OEM-designed flex-fuel vehicles. *(Pg 9)*
Senior Citizens (Care and Protection of Rights) Bill, 2026	Keralam's first-in-India State law: recognises living wills, regulates care centres, creates a Geriatric Care Certification Framework. *(Pg 3)*
National Service Act, 1972	The elaborate statutory model for compulsory professional service — liability, notice, remuneration, reinstatement — that the Census Act lacks. *(Pg 5)*
Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita — Sections 192, 353(2)	Public mischief and spreading false or alarming information — invoked against the vlogger in Fort Kochi. *(Pg 14)*
Companies Act — Articles 118, 104B	Selection Committee requirement and the affirmative vote of specified directors, cited in the Tata Sons dispute. *(Pg 10)*
Fund for Loss and Damage (COP27, 2022)	Operationalised 2023; $21.6 mn to Nepal is its first disaster allocation, against $822 mn pledged and 119 countries waiting. *(Pg 12)*

A CLOSING NOTE

Every item in this edition was selected from a single day's newspaper on one test: does it touch the UPSC syllabus? The two Sport pages, the Classifieds and Tenders pages, the Calendar page with its crossword, Sudoku, comic strips and horoscope, the IWAI and Mission Shakti advertorials, the DDA and rugby full-page advertisements, the court proclamation notices, local crime reports and celebrity copy have all been removed. What remains has been re-written in brief, grouped by General Studies paper, and annotated with the syllabus link.

Photographs, charts and data are reproduced from the source edition for study use. This digest is not affiliated with The Indian Express or with any examination authority; please consult the original newspaper for full reports.

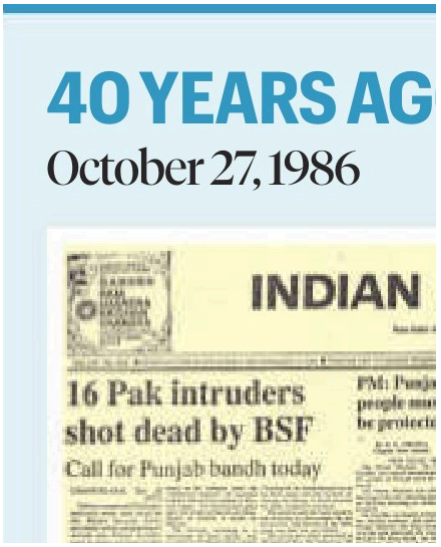
TERMS, BODIES AND NUMBERS

- **ERONET / ECINet** — the ECI's electoral roll platforms; only an ERO may add, delete or modify an entry.
- **"Mapping"** — linking an applicant to the 2002/2003 SIR entry of self, parents or grandparents, via the Additional Declaration annexed to Form 6.
- **DAC & AoN** — Defence Acquisition Council; Acceptance of Necessity is the first stage of the Defence Acquisition Procedure.
- **VSHORADS / C-UAS / AODS / LMRH / GSRS** — the five acronyms from the ₹2.12 lakh crore clearance.
- **Mecca pact** — Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Pakistan, signed August 2026; Egypt's parliament has now authorised defending Saudi Arabia.
- **Ship-to-ship (STS) transfer** — a shuttle tanker carries oil through the Strait of Hormuz and transfers it to a waiting vessel outside.
- **RELIEF / EPM / ECGC** — Resilience & Logistics Intervention for Exporters under the Export Promotion Mission; ECGC gives up to 100% cover for war-related risk.
- **ASUSE / PLFS / ASI** — the three statistical surveys being aligned to the financial year; female LFPR 34.6% against 77.4% for men.
- **AEOI / CRS / FATCA** — the automatic information-exchange frameworks behind the FAST-DS disclosure scheme.
- **ENSO · Niño 3.4 · RONI** — El Niño is declared when the three-month average RONI exceeds +0.5°C; the current event is forecast at 3.8°C above normal.
- **Big Four** — spectacled cobra, common krait, Russell's viper and saw-scaled viper; ~50,000 snakebite deaths a year in India.
- **Deposit Refund Scheme** — Uttarakhand ₹10 a bottle (collection up from 20-22% to ~90%); Goa ₹5; Delhi considering ₹1-2.
- **Buxa Tiger Reserve** — ~760 sq km in Alipurduar, West Bengal; tigress T-138 airlifted from Valmiki Tiger Reserve, Bihar.
- **Fifth plenum** — the fifth meeting of the Chinese Communist Party's Central Committee cohort formed in 2022.
- **BRICS Parliamentary Forum** — 12th edition, theme "Strengthening Parliaments for People-Centric Development"; BRICS is ~49.5% of world population.

MAINS PRACTICE

1. A decision recorded as unanimous is not the same as a decision taken collectively. Examine this distinction with reference to the functioning of a multi-member constitutional body. *(GS II, 250 words)*
2. "Subordinate legislation cannot travel beyond its parent statute." Discuss with reference to the appointment of private citizens as Census enumerators and the scope of Article 23(2). *(GS II, 250 words)*
3. A voter who is deleted and then asked to register afresh has not been restored but reclassified. Examine the procedural safeguards necessary in electoral roll revision. *(GS II, 150 words)*
4. Keralam's senior citizens legislation treats ageing as a question of rights rather than of welfare. Evaluate this shift and its implications for other States facing demographic transition. *(GS I / GS II, 250 words)*
5. India has solved the problem of electricity scarcity and inherited the problem of electricity surplus. Discuss, with reference to storage and transmission. *(GS III, 250 words)*
6. Compensation is not charity. Examine the principle underlying the Fund for Loss and Damage and the obstacles to its effective functioning. *(GS III, 250 words)*
7. When courts are too slow, the police become judges. Critically examine the criminalisation of civil disputes in India and suggest reforms. *(GS II / GS IV, 250 words)*
8. "A criminal investigation runs on evidence that must survive cross-examination; social media runs on plausibility, outrage and repetition." Discuss the implications for institutional credibility. *(GS IV, 250 words)*
9. India does not have a shortage of culture, only of strategy. Comment on the case for a deliberate national soft-power policy. *(Essay)*

FORTY YEARS AGO · OCTOBER 27, 1986


40 YEARS AG
October 27, 1986
INDIAN
16 Pak intruders shot dead by BSF
Call for Punjab bandh today

Pakistani intruders shot dead. Sixteen suspected Pakistani nationals were shot dead by Border Security Force personnel while attempting to intrude into Indian territory even as major political parties in Punjab gave a call for a *bandh* in the state and Chandigarh to protest against the gunning down of seven persons in Khubhan village. Thirteen intruders were killed in the Khemkaran area in Punjab, while two were shot dead in Anoopgarh and one in the Sriganganagar area of Rajasthan in the last 24 hours. In a fresh spurt of incidents, terrorists shot dead an employee of a liquor shop near Moga and two ex-servicemen, in separate incidents, were deprived of their arms in Amritsar district.

PM on the security situation. The Prime Minister issued instructions that the people in Punjab must be protected, and called a meeting of the law-enforcing agencies to review the situation.

Sri Lanka conflict proposal. Sri Lankan Tamil militant groups will on November 3 give their views on the latest proposals of the island government to solve the ethnic issue to the Tamil Nadu Chief Minister. Leaders of the militant groups discussed the proposals with the Chief Minister at the state secretariat for about 90 minutes.

> **WHY IT MATTERS** — Punjab militancy in the 1980s and the road to the Rajiv–Longowal Accord; India's role in the Sri Lankan ethnic conflict before the IPKF. Both are standing modern-history and IR themes.